

JÖNKÖPING UNIVERSITY
Jönköping International
Business School

Buying to Balance: Venture Clienting as a Mechanism for Organizational Ambidexterity

MASTER THESIS WITHIN: *Business Administration*

NUMBER OF CREDITS: *30*

PROGRAMME OF STUDY: *Global Management*

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JÖNKÖPING May 2026

Master Thesis in Business Administration

Title: "Buying to Balance: Venture Clienting as a Mechanism for Organizational Ambidexterity"

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Date: 2026-05-24

Key terms: Venture clienting, Venture client unit, Organizational ambidexterity, Corporate venture capital

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Abstract

Background: Venture clienting is a relatively new innovation vehicle that is continuously gaining more attention. The core premise is that established companies act as early customers of innovative startups. With startup solutions, established companies seek to solve their internal problems that would require significant resources to develop internally. Furthermore, venture clienting can contribute to the balance between exploitation and exploration within the organization, which is also known as organizational ambidexterity.

Purpose: Although gaining more interest, venture clienting still remains under researched as a topic. Previous literature is focused on the process of venture clienting and comparing the vehicle with corporate venture capital. This thesis aims to understand how companies use and embed venture clienting within the organization and how shapes the balance between exploitation and exploration.

Method: This study adopts a qualitative abductive research design. For the research, a total of 17 semi-structured interviews were conducted, out of which 11 were organizations utilizing venture clienting, and six were venture clienting consultancy service providers. For data analysis, thematic analysis was used, and the findings were connected to the ambidexterity theory.

Conclusion: Empirical findings suggest that venture clienting has the potential to contribute to organizational ambidexterity. However, companies seeking to have an effective venture clienting process are suggested to carefully consider where the venture client unit is anchored, invest in internal communication, and stakeholder involvement and engagement. Based on the previous literature and empirical findings, a conceptual model of venture clienting as an ambidextrous vehicle was created.

DECLARATION

We hereby declare that this thesis represents our own work.

We declare that we have obtained the necessary ethical approval (e.g., GDPR) and acknowledged our obligations and the rights of the participants/respondents in the research.

We have read and applied the Jönköping University's current research ethics guidelines with regards to the use of artificial intelligence (AI) tool in this work as presented in the Course Guide. During the preparation of this work the authors used the following AI tools and the purpose for their use.

AI tools used:

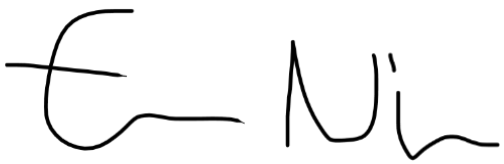
Claude was used for refining sentences and assisting with initial coding (providing quotes from interview scripts)

ChatGPT was used for refining sentences.

Turboscribe was used for generating a transcript from recorded audio.

DeepL was used to translate interview scripts from German and Finnish to English.

As authors, we have reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the thesis.



Emma Liisa Nieminen

Stockholm, May 24, 2026



Rebecca Steinke

Osnabrück, May 24, 2026

Acknowledgements

We would first like to thank our thesis supervisor, Professor Leona Achtenhagen, for her great guidance during this thesis writing period. She guided and challenged us from the beginning, pushing us to do our best work. We would also like to thank her for being flexible with our different schedules due to an internship and work. She always provided great feedback and displayed her deep interest in our success, which we truly appreciate.

We are also thankful for our thesis seminar group. Without our discussions, new perspectives, and challenging our thesis, it would have been incomplete. We wish you all the best for the future!

Furthermore, as our thesis is purely based on empirical data collected through interviews, we would like to express our deep gratitude to every interviewee participating in this study. Your insight and expertise on such a limitedly explored topic enabled us to gain a deep understanding of venture clienting and its impact on organizational ambidexterity. It was delightful to see how exited everyone involved in Venture Clienting was to talk about this topic and push it further into the academic world.

Lastly, we would like to thank Jönköping International Business School for the last two years of our Master's. We deeply enjoyed our program Global Management and the time spent at the university, even in stressful periods and will always remember this time!

Thank you!

Emma and Rebecca

Abbreviations

CVC	Corporate Venture Capital
OA	Organizational Ambidexterity
SP	Service Provider
VCL	Venture Clienting
VCU	Venture Client Unit

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1. Introduction

This introduction outlines the background and motivation of the study, positioning venture clienting within the broader context of corporate innovation and venturing. It begins by looking at the reasons why firms need to look beyond their organizational boundaries and the role of ambidexterity before introducing venture clienting as an emerging response. Lastly, it will identify the theoretical and empirical gaps that the study aims to address.

In many industries, product lifecycles are shrinking, digital technologies are reshaping value chains, and new entrants are challenging established corporations (Fernández & Rodriguez, 2022; Si & Chen, 2020). As a result, corporations increasingly face pressure to innovate at a faster level while simultaneously maintaining cost efficiency and strategic flexibility (O'Reilly & Tushman, 2013). For that, they both need to renew their capabilities while also maintaining efficiency in their existing operations. This dual requirement reflects the long-established trade-off between exploration and exploitation (March, 1991). While exploitation involves refining existing knowledge and routines for reliable, imminent returns, exploration means experimenting with new alternatives at the cost of uncertainty and distant payoffs.

Balancing these activities, called ambidexterity, is considered critical for long-term firm survival and growth (Tushman & O'Reilly, 1996). With that, however, multiple challenges come along: exploration and exploitation compete for scarce organizational resources, managerial attention, and strategic prioritization. While corporations focusing on exploitation risk technological obsolescence and strategic rigidity, those emphasizing exploration may face inefficiencies and deteriorating short-term performance. When economic uncertainty arises and budgets are cut, innovation units are often affected, making it increasingly difficult for corporations to sustain the balance between exploitation and exploration (Lavie et al., 2010). As a response, firms turn toward external innovation vehicles to complement internal R&D efforts and to access new knowledge, technologies, and business models beyond their organizational boundaries (Cassiman & Veugelers, 2006).

Corporate Venturing is a prominent approach to external innovation and includes different instruments such as corporate venture capital (CVC), venture building, incubators, accelerators, alliances, and internal venture units (Keil, 2004). One of the most well-known is

CVC, where corporates spread their investment portfolio through equity investments across multiple startups. They aim to identify high-potential ventures that may generate financial returns or strategic value in the future.

While these established approaches provide access to external innovation, they often involve high upfront financial commitments, uncertain time-horizons, and potential strategic misalignments. Especially in times of economic volatility, budget constraints, and shifting competitive landscapes, firms increasingly seek innovation mechanisms that are faster, more flexible, and involve fewer resources (Banholzer et al., 2025).

Within this context, venture clienting (VCL) has gained increasing attention, especially in large corporations (Gimmy, 2023). VCL differs fundamentally from traditional venturing activities in a way that the corporation does not invest in the startup but acts as an early client. The process then involves piloting, testing, and potentially adapting and scaling the startup's solution within its own operations (Haarmann et al., 2023). This model shifts the relationship from investor to client and focuses on operational implementation and strategic fit rather than financial involvement.

One of the most prominent early adopters of VCL is the BMW Startup Garage, founded in 2015 by Gregor Gimmy (Drechsler, 2015). The Startup Garage institutionalized the concept of the "venture client" by systematically integrating startups into BMW's supplier and innovation processes. However, also companies such as Bosch, MAN, Scania, Husqvarna, REHAU, and many more have adopted VCL into their organizations, with some of them even building independent entities working as a venture client unit (VCU) (27pilots, 2025, Combient Foundry, 2025 & REHAU New Ventures, 2025).

While CVC tends to be primarily exploration-oriented, venture clienting may enable a more balanced ambidextrous approach. By directly integrating external solutions into existing processes and products, VCL seems to simultaneously support exploration of innovative technologies and exploitation through implementation and scaling. This operational approach positions VCL as a potentially beneficial vehicle for achieving ambidexterity without the long-term financial commitment of equity-based models.

Current research on external innovation is mostly focused on equity-based approaches, with CVC receiving a considerably large amount of attention, particularly around governance,

financial and strategic returns, and ambidexterity (Pinkow & Iversen, 2020). Non-equity approaches, however, risk being treated as less strategically relevant, leaving them undertheorized compared to their equity-based counterparts (Heiduk et al., 2025).

Ambidexterity theory suggests that integrating exploration into exploitative structures creates tensions between speed and reliability, experimentation and standardization, and flexibility and process stability. While CVC manages these tensions through structural separation, venture clienting seems to integrate exploration operationally rather than structurally. However, it remains academically unclear in which way VCL supports, hinders, or reconfigures ambidexterity in corporations.

We can already see that venture clienting shifts the logic from ownership-based exploration (CVC) to usage-based validation, which may signal a move toward more operationally embedded exploration. However, there is limited evidence on whether firms are shifting from CVC toward VCL and, therefore, whether and how ambidexterity might be affected.

With this study, we aim to make both theoretical and empirical, but also practical and managerial contributions to the topic of venture clienting. Through a multiple case study involving expert interviews and using additional secondary data, we want to further conceptualize VCL as a non-equity mode of external innovation and how it differentiates in terms of governance logic, integration mechanisms, and organizational implications. Additionally, we aim to connect VCL with ambidexterity theory and investigate how VCL might influence or shift the balance between exploration and exploitation.

From the empirical perspective, the thesis wants to provide in-depth qualitative insights into how firms design, implement, and operationalize venture clienting in practice. Additionally, we will explore how organizations use VCL in relation to other corporate venturing vehicles. Lastly, based on qualitative data, we will explore the dynamics between VCL, exploration, and exploitation.

Further, there will be practical and managerial contributions, including how managers can structure and govern VCL effectively and what key success factors and organizational challenges in embedding external innovation might be. This paper aims at providing guidance on how firms can leverage VCL to access startup innovation while keeping strategic alignment and to influence the firm's balance between exploration and exploitation.

2. Literature Review

This chapter examines relevant existing academic literature. Here, a theoretical background for how organizations manage external innovation is provided, with specific focus on corporate entrepreneurship, corporate venturing, and venture clienting. Previous literature highlights the challenges companies are facing when managing ambidexterity (March, 1991; Raisch & Birkinshaw, 2008), but also emphasizes the growing importance of external collaboration between established companies and startups (Dushnitsky & Lenox, 2006; Pinkow & Iversen, 2020). Together, the reviewed previous and relevant research provides the needed theoretical background for this study. Additionally, the key theory used in this study, ambidexterity, and its relevance to this research are explained.

2.1 Exploration and Exploitation in Corporate Innovation - Ambidexterity

Previous literature highlights the importance of the ambidextrous organization, meaning the balance between activities related to exploration and exploitation for an organization's growth (Brix, 2019; March, 1991; Tushman & O'Reilly, 1996).

Exploration includes search, variation, experimentation, and discovery, aiming to develop new capabilities and knowledge. In other words, exploration seeks to create new knowledge, and the company aims to search for unfamiliar technologies and resources to generate variation (Lee et al., 2018). In contrast, exploitation refers to seeking to refine and extend the existing competencies through actions including selection, efficiency, and implementation (Raisch & Birkinshaw, 2008). However, it is often complicated to maintain the optimal balance as both compete for scarce resources. Uncertainty and slow performance in learning outcomes are often characteristics of exploration; however, it allows companies to create radical innovations in the long run, making it vital for the longevity of the organization.

Exploitation, on the other hand, is considered faster, more efficient, and more predictable; however, creating smaller innovations (Lee et al., 2018).

Today, established companies operate in a highly competitive environment that continuously forces organizations to reconfigure operations to meet the changing demand (Krause-Söhner, 2021, p. 2). Established companies overly emphasizing that exploitation reduces the learning of new skills and can become captive to outdated technology and skills that negatively affect the long-term growth of the company. At the same time, when established companies overly concentrate on exploration, the organization might risk utilizing resources without satisfying results, therefore harming the company's short-term benefits. Due to that, especially nowadays, organizational ambidexterity can be considered crucial for the company's long-term success and growth (Krause-Söhner, 2021, p. 9). Simsek (2009, p. 618) further highlights that organizational ambidexterity (OA) is not necessarily concerned with the simultaneous pursuit of exploration and exploitation, but rather companies might want to focus on having a dynamic balance, based on priorities during different demands.

To overcome the challenges related to the optimal balance between exploitation and exploration, OA researchers have come up with structural, contextual, and leadership-based solutions (Raisch & Birkinshaw, 2008). It is suggested in previous academic works on structural OA that exploration and exploitation activities might need to be separated in certain organizational business units. However, contextual OA focuses on organizational context and the simultaneous pursuit of exploration and exploitation within the same unit. The Leadership-based solution highlights the role of the top management of the established company in balancing the two activities (Raisch & Birkinshaw, 2008; Krause-Söhner, 2021, p. 25).

2.2 Corporate Entrepreneurship

Corporate entrepreneurship is a way through which companies seek to support exploration and innovation. There is no single precise definition of corporate entrepreneurship: Some scholars suggest it to be an intra-firm process resulting in new business development, while others consider it to be a firm-level strategic posture intended to create innovation, be proactive, and risk-taking (Bouchard, 2017, p. 8). Wolcott and Lippitz (2007) define corporate entrepreneurship as a process where teams in established companies conceive, foster, launch, and manage a new business that may be distinct from the parent company but utilizes the parent company's resources. Therefore, corporate entrepreneurship can be summarized as the development of new business opportunities and innovations within established organizations. Corporate entrepreneurship can be divided into two components: internal and external

corporate entrepreneurship. Internal corporate entrepreneurship consists of intrapreneurship, where individuals from the organization seek new business opportunities (Antoncic & Hisrich, 2001), and strategic renewal, which includes strengthening the company's competitiveness through reconfiguring their resources (Schmitt et al., 2018). External corporate entrepreneurship, on the other hand, includes partnerships with innovative actors outside the organization to create new businesses outside the company's organizational boundaries. (Narayanan et al., 2009).

However, implementing entrepreneurial activities internally may be challenging in large, established companies due to risk aversion, bureaucracy, and an efficiency-focused atmosphere. Therefore, organizations can utilize externally sourced innovations to support their internal entrepreneurial activities. Within this framework, venture clienting can be seen as a vehicle enabling corporate entrepreneurship by providing established companies access to external innovation and enabling experimentation with startup innovations without significant investment.

2.3 Corporate Venturing as a Vehicle for External Exploration

Generally, creating new business for an existing company through building, partnering, or investing is called corporate venturing (Weiss et al., 2024). Corporate venturing is often considered as a subset of corporate entrepreneurship, which may include corporate venture capital (CVC), internal venture units, accelerators, incubators, and strategic alliances with chosen startups (Keil, 2004). Different models of corporate venturing can be distinguished by the involvement of equity involvement, investment horizon, and degree of integration. With these vehicles, established companies can gain access to external novel innovations while maintaining a degree of strategic control.

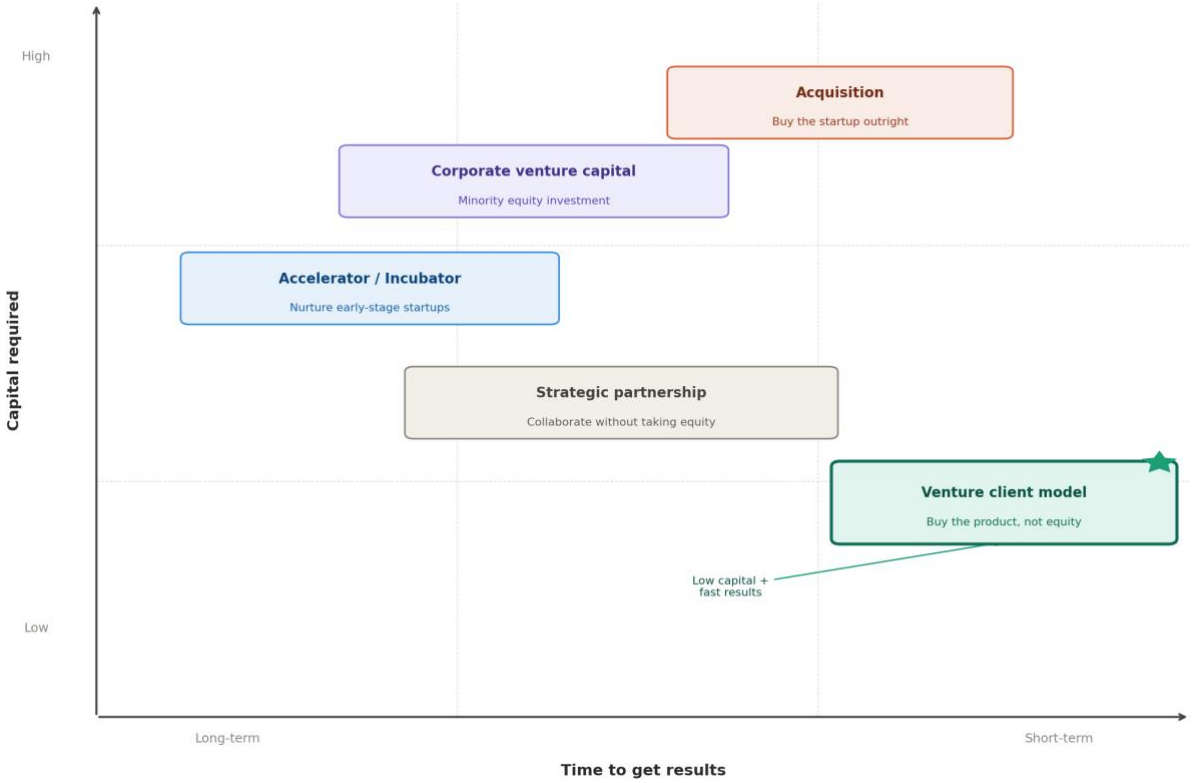


Figure 1: Based on Haarmann et al. (2023, p. 346)

The figure above shows how different corporate venturing vehicles are positioned in relation to time horizon and required capital. Time horizon refers to the time each vehicle requires to generate results, and capital refers to the amount of capital involved (Haarmann et al., 2023, p. 346). Venture clienting is positioned in the lower right corner, meaning the most advantageous position. The matrix suggests venture clienting to be the fastest showing results and requiring the least amount of capital, compared to other common corporate venturing vehicles. For instance, acquisitions come near VCL with a time horizon; however, it often requires significantly higher investment. Capital requirements of strategic partnerships, on the other hand, are lower compared to acquisitions, CVC, and accelerators; however, it often requires more time than VCL and acquisitions. CVC requires more investment than other vehicles but is also more long-term horizontal when it comes to feasible results. Lastly, using accelerators is usually the most long-term decision out of the five innovation vehicles and places in the middle regarding the required capital.

In today's rapidly changing, volatile, and uncertain business environment, companies need to continuously seek to adapt and gain a competitive edge for profitable growth (Weiss et al., 2024). Companies might simultaneously need to address the challenges of improving their

present business and developing new business opportunities. In response, companies have turned towards corporate ventures as a mechanism to gain access to external innovation, enhancing their competitiveness (Bruchhage et al., 2024; Haarmann et al., 2024). The number of global corporate venture deals nearly doubled but also the related investments quadrupled between 2012 and 2015 (Gimmy et al., 2017), indicating a clear shift in interest.

2.3.1 Corporate Venture Capital

Corporate venture capital is one of the most well-known forms of corporate venturing, where established firms invest in independent startup ventures (Pinkow & Iversen, 2020). This form is used by established companies to get access to emerging technologies, external knowledge, and financial returns beyond internal R&D (Dushnitsky & Lenox, 2006; Maula et al., 2005; Pinkow & Iversen, 2020). Additionally, CVC allows established companies to build strong connections with entrepreneurial actors within their field, strengthening the established companies' strategic competitiveness. Recent meta-analytic research indicates that investments in CVC are positively associated with different strategic performance outcomes, including the introduction of new products and patent activity (Haslanger et al., 2023). However, the same research mentions finding no evidence of a positive correlation between CVC investments and higher financial performance, indicating that CVC investments are potentially used for strategic purposes.

The relationship between CVC and OA has been widely discussed in previous literature. Generally, CVC has mainly been linked only to explorative learning. Still, some studies have suggested that CVC activities are not limited only to exploration, but they can also contribute to exploitative learning (Lee at al., 2018; Cambell et al., 2008). However, literature highlights the difference in the level of autonomy needed for explorative and exploitative learning activities. Generally, explorative learning requires great autonomy as it seeks to generate new knowledge, while exploitative learning is recommended to be done within the company, utilizing the company's existing knowledge (Lee et al., 2018).

Although corporate venturing has gained popularity, literature recognizes challenges in traditional corporate venturing models. Previous literature highlights limited speed and delayed impact, high organizational complexity, and uncertainty related to value realization as the main challenges (Gimmy et al., 2017; Haarmann et al., 2023; Bruchhage et al., 2024). CVC is a complex and resource-intensive model because external knowledge needs to be integrated, and

internal resources need to be mobilized. Therefore, although CVC has the potential to create valuable knowledge, it also holds great risks as failures are able to disrupt the company's new product development (Bendig et al., 2023). Furthermore, Gimmy et al. (2017) recognize three key threats potentially leading CVC to fail: First, the ability of established companies to gain access to the top-performing startups. Secondly, approximately only 20% of technologies stemming from CVC get enough attention to start a pilot project; therefore, missing many opportunities. Lastly, CVC can be complex to operate, making the process slow and therefore costly, indicating that traditional corporate venturing models may fail in achieving the expected results.

As a result, previous scholars increasingly recognize that the established traditional corporate venturing models may not be optimal for achieving the desired goals. These models often struggle to deliver tangible innovation outcomes within the scheduled timeframe and may therefore be inefficient investments. The challenges of these traditional forms have led to increasing interest in alternative models of collaboration, which highlight speed, execution, and direct business impact.

2.3.2 Venture Building

Venture building, often referred to as the startup studio model, is a relatively new, innovative approach supporting corporate entrepreneurship and is distinct from other traditional models (Belingheri & Lechner, 2025; De Alvarega et al., 2023). In this model, multiple startups are created and scaled by the central organization to increase the chance of success for each of the ventures. Typical characteristics of this model are shared infrastructure, resources, and other expertise provided by the studio (Belingheri & Lechner, 2025; De Sterke, 2020). Therefore, the philosophy behind the model is to transform innovations into scalable businesses through reducing uncertainty, leveraging capabilities, and the financial backing of the mothership. The main advantage of venture building is its favorable conditions, allowing companies to develop but also scale ideas, as it works as a search engine with fewer boundaries for the central organization (De Sterke, 2020).

2.3.3 Venture Clienting: A Non-Equity Corporate Venturing Model

The venture clienting (VCL) model is a form of collaborating with startups, where startups' solutions are directly integrated into the company's products, processes, or business models.

Meaning that established companies do not only invest in startups, but rather they become early customers of a startup's solution through piloting it in their own products, processes, or business models (Bruchhage et al., 2024). Other established corporate venturing vehicles seem not to be ideal for integrating startup innovation into the core business, which has led established companies to start utilizing the venture client model (Haarmann et al, 2024). To grasp the scale of the VCL trend, from 2013 to 2019, the venture client model adoption among leading global corporations grew by 42% (Capella et al., 2025). The major distinguishing aspect between venture clienting and traditional corporate venturing models is that VCL is intended to contribute directly to the competitiveness and innovation of established companies through solving relevant challenges (Haarmann et al., 2024). Further distinguishing aspects between CVC and VCL are time horizon, logic of integration, and feedback cycles (Heiduk et al., 2025). CVC includes equity stakes and long-term horizons and is aimed at exploring beyond the company's current core business. VCL, on the other hand, bypasses equity as the company becomes an early customer through pilot contracts (Haarmann et al., 2024). As the collaboration begins straight with piloting the solution in an established company's existing operations, VCL can generate rapid learning cycles, as long as the organization can effectively absorb external innovations.

Previous research additionally points out that the VCL innovation process goes beyond that of CVC as it tests the solution in the incubation phase and therefore validates the problem-solution fit before the established company subsequently goes into implementation and scaling of a solution (Heiduk et al., 2025). Therefore, VCL's ability to contribute with far lower investment and at a higher pace greatly distinguishes it from CVC.

Furthermore, established companies have faced challenges in acquiring the top startups through traditional corporate venturing methods, as startups do not consider that they benefit enough from the collaboration (Gimmy et al., 2017). However, VCL seems to be an attractive form of collaboration for high-performing startups, as they receive direct revenue, needed resources, specific industry and technical knowledge, and customer feedback (Haarmann et al., 2023). Furthermore, research conducted by Heiduk et al. (2025) suggests that CVCs are more focused on exploration, while VCLs often have a more balanced ambidextrous approach.

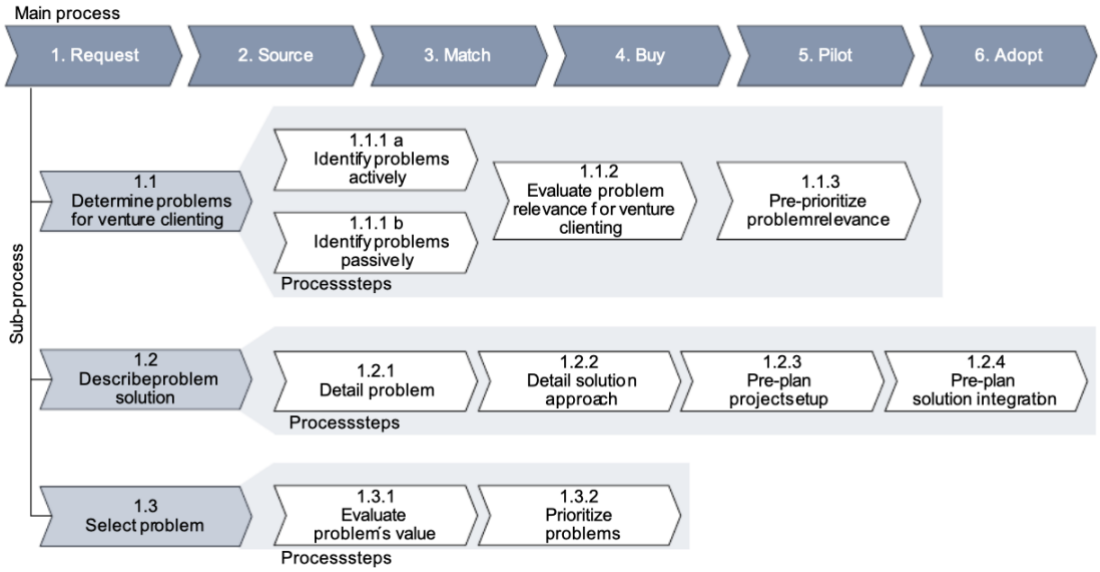


Figure 2: (Bruchhage et al., 2024, p. 7)

Venture clienting often follows a structured multi-step process, which was theorized by Haarmann et al (2023). Their definition of the includes the phases: request, source, match, buy, pilot, and adopt The request phase is a particularly important step where the challenges are identified, specified, and finally prioritized. Related to this phase, previous literature has distinguished two different approaches: push and pull. In the pull approach, the established company has identified a concrete problem within the business internally before scouting a startup to collaborate with. In contrast, the push approach starts with identifying a startup technology, which, for the established company, sources a suitable case from the company (Haarmann et al., 2023; Bruchhage et al., 2024). These approaches illustrate that venture clienting can be both problem-driven and technology-driven.

The next phase, source, is where the firm scouts for relevant startups that are potentially able to address the problem defined in the request phase. Following the source phase comes matching, where these chosen startups are being assessed in greater depth and further aligned with internal stakeholders. The buy phase then includes agreeing to the collaboration and signing contractual agreements for enabling the next phase, piloting. The pilot phase includes the actual testing of the startup's solution in the real-world conditions of the established company. This phase is crucial in terms of the future of the collaboration or partnership between the startup and the established company. Finally, the adoption phase, which involves a more comprehensive integration and scaling of the solution within the company. In case of

successful piloting, the startup may potentially become a long-term supplier or strategic partner for the company (Haarmann et al., 2023).

2.4 Startup Collaboration as a Mechanism for Exploration

A startup is a newly created company, partnership, or temporary organization designed to explore new scalable and repeatable business models (Spender et al., 2017). Startups have started to be increasingly attractive collaboration partners for large organizations for many reasons.

The fundamental premise in venture clienting is that startups can provide established companies with access to capabilities that are difficult to develop internally by the companies themselves. Startups can be seen as attractive partners because of new innovative ideas, the latest technology, new business models, and the niche knowledge they often hold. Furthermore, startups are known to be more agile, flexible, and have a higher tolerance for risks, making the company more susceptible to innovations.

Venture clienting enables established companies to integrate startup solutions directly into their operations without the need for full ownership or any long-term contract commitments. Therefore, this model gives established companies the benefits of startup innovations and new knowledge while simultaneously maintaining their strategic flexibility (Haarmann et al., 2023). Gimmy et al. (2017) further agree that venture clienting can efficiently allow established companies to leverage the capabilities of startups, which would not be possible or as efficient with traditional investment vehicles.

Additionally, established companies tend to have more established and strict processes and organizational culture (Damberg et al., 2025, p. 25), potentially creating conflicts between the established company and the startup. Furthermore, established companies and startups may have barriers in communication and relationships, which therefore potentially cause misunderstandings and inefficiencies (Banka et al., 2024). Therefore, the realization of competitive benefits depends not only on the capabilities the startup has, but also on the established company's ability to integrate external solutions into its operations (Bruchhage et al., 2024). Furthermore, collaborations with startups incorporate risks and challenges caused by the startup's maturity. Startups are young ventures with often underdeveloped processes and unrobust operations and finance, making them a more uncertain supplier (Damberg et al.,

2025, p. 116). However, their cutting-edge technologies and original innovations still make them extremely attractive partners.

2.5 Research Gap

Despite its growing practical relevance, venture clienting remains conceptually underdeveloped in academic work (Haarmann et al., 2023). The model has drawn significant interest after its introduction through the startup garage initiative conducted by BMW. Still, academic research remains fragmented, and further exploration around the model is highly needed. There is no obvious theoretical consensus on the definition, process, or how VCL works organizationally. Questions left open by current literature are also how established companies embed VCL to enable its success, whether firms use it as a substitute or an addition to equity-based approaches, and how it might impact ambidexterity and the balance between exploration and exploitation.

Altogether, there are severe gaps in research both about the general theorization, organization and shift toward venture clienting, but also how it relates to ambidexterity. We need to understand how VCL is organized internally as well as how corporates are using it among other corporate venturing vehicles. Furthermore, the relationship with ambidexterity needs clarification as it is unclear whether venture clienting functions as a vehicle of ambidexterity, and if so, how. Lastly, this study looks at the role of service providers who are supporting corporations in building their venture clienting units.

Based on the determined research gaps, this paper will focus on solving the following research question: *How do corporations use and embed venture clienting to integrate externally sourced innovations within firms, and how does the vehicle shape the balance between exploration and exploitation in ambidexterity theory?*

3 Methodology

This chapter explains the methodological choices and research approach of this study. First, the research philosophy, critical realism ontology, and constructionism epistemology are justified. Then, the decision to design the research as a qualitative multi-case study is explained. Furthermore, the data collection methods are unveiled, along with case profiles of each company participating in the research. Moreover, online posts and reports available on the internet were used as secondary data. Further, we explain the decisions for using an abductive approach and thematic analysis for the data analysis. Finally, efforts to ensure research quality and ethical considerations are presented.

3.1 Research Philosophy

To clarify the methodological choices of this research, the philosophical assumptions of the research must be stated. For this research, we consider critical realism to best describe the nature of reality, and constructionism to how that reality is known. Critical realist ontology assumes that a reality exists independently of individuals' perceptions and experiences, but the reality consists of underlying structures that cannot always be observed directly (Fletcher, 2016). Critical realism consists of three levels: The empirical level, meaning how individuals experience events. The middle (actual) level describes where there is no filter of human experience, meaning that events occur whether or not individuals experience or interpret them. Third, the final (real) level, which consists of causal structures or mechanisms, which are inherent properties in a structure or object acting as causal forces producing events (Fletcher, 2016). We consider this suitable as our ontology as it assumes that organizational processes exist independently of individuals' perception, while it simultaneously recognizes that these processes are being experienced differently by different actors involved. As this research seeks to study how corporations embed venture clienting to integrate externally sourced innovations, it is vital to examine the underlying mechanisms of the process, but also the perspectives of the actors involved. Therefore, critical realism allows to study real organizational phenomena while simultaneously acknowledging different viewpoints.

We consider the constructionism epistemology viewpoint suitable for this research as it suggests reality to be socially constructed, with its meaning being given by people's

interactions, rather than being objective and exterior (Easterby-Smith & Mark, 2021). Since this research seeks to understand how established firms embed venture clienting to enable the integration of externally sourced innovations and how it can manage exploration and exploitation, it is essential to capture the perspectives of the actors involved in it. Therefore, the constructionist epistemology supports this study's objective to gain insights into how venture clienting is perceived and implemented.

3.2 Research Design

The philosophical perspectives and research approach affect the decisions related to the research design. Research can be conducted by different approaches, including qualitative, quantitative, and mixed research designs (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). A qualitative approach utilizes directed conversations focusing on a specific topic through open-ended questions, allowing rich and detailed insight. Therefore, for this study, a qualitative research design is considered the most efficient and appropriate in order to gain valuable and comprehensive insights into how venture clienting is experienced and implemented in practice. Qualitative research allows to conduct more in-depth exploration on such a complex organizational process and helps to identify the mechanisms behind it. Furthermore, our study's aim is to support the theory building on how venture clienting is used to integrate externally sourced innovation and what the role of third parties is in the process. Therefore, an abductive approach is adopted, aiming to develop theoretical insight from the empirical findings with the support of existing theories. Moreover, this research approach allows theory to emerge through comparing empirical observations across different cases with the structure and support of existing theories.

A multi-case study was found to be the most suitable approach for this study as it allows for a deeper understanding of the phenomenon through the perspectives of multiple actors. A multi-case includes using multiple cases to create theoretical constructs, propositions, and midrange theory from empirical evidence (Eisenhardt, 1989). In this approach, each case acts as a separate experiment that stands as an independent analytical unit. These cases act as replications, contrasts, and extensions of the emerging theory (Eisenhardt & Graebner, 2007). Furthermore, including multiple cases in the research enables us to draw strong, testable, interesting, and accurate conclusions and build a theory around venture clienting (Yin, 2018; Eisenhardt & Graebner, 2007). Therefore, the multi-case approach allows us to identify

patterns and underlying mechanisms and enables the study to move beyond context-specific insight.

Although a single case study could provide deep and valuable insight for the research, the purpose of this research is to understand how venture clienting functions and enables firms to use it to integrate externally sourced innovations across different contexts. Therefore, to gain more comprehensive and generalizable knowledge, the multi-case approach offers better conditions. The use of a single-case study approach would reduce the transferability of the study, as the surroundings of a single case may be unique, which therefore makes the approach unsuitable for our research aims.

3.3 Data Collection

This study is primarily based on primary qualitative data, which is collected through semi-structured interviews, which helps explore the complex organizational processes of venture clienting and embedding external innovation (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). Using mostly primary qualitative data allows access to first-hand insights from experts directly involved in VCL activities. At the same time, secondary textual data was used. This mainly includes the websites of the case corporates and their venture client units, but also information from LinkedIn posts and other publicly available content. The use of this data is mainly to support our cases and additionally examine public information on the existence of VCL units, processes, and the public perception. Secondary data gives us the advantage of complementing the data found in the interviews, while not fully relying on it.

3.3.1 Sampling

Within this section, the paper's sampling strategy will be presented. A sampling strategy is chosen according to the goal of the research. As this paper aims at identifying patterns across the cases, we have chosen the purposive sampling strategy, choosing experts based on their expertise and involvement in VCL (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). As the venture client model seems to be mainly spread on the European continent, the main focus was on DACH and Nordic companies, which will represent our cases. While the most relevant service providers were known beforehand, corporates were mainly chosen based on the reference client lists on the service providers' websites. With a limited availability of VCL units and increasing interest in interviewing those, there have sometimes been difficulties in gaining interview partners.

However, throughout the interviewing process, we also made use of the snowball sampling strategy, and more participants were referred to us. Altogether, the main criteria within our purposive sampling strategy were: Working within or being the head of a VCU, consulting on VCL, and being established firms located in the DACH region or Nordics. Within the sample, we separated the interviewees into two categories: First the case representatives, and second, the additional perspective from the service providers. Based on this, we are working in total with ten cases, which will be presented after the data description, one additional interviewee from a venture architect perspective, and six service providers from three different firms, reaching a total sample size of 17.

3.3.2 Primary Data

The primary qualitative data were collected through semi-structured expert interviews (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). The method of semi-structured interviews leans on an interview guide that primarily aims at structuring the interview and providing comparability across interviews; however, offers room for additions and potential follow-up questions. This interview guide has a different design according to each of the two target groups: VCL service providers and corporates, representing our cases. While it is partly equal, especially regarding the basics of VCL, some sections vary accordingly. This offers us both comparable answers, but also different views from different actors involved in the process. The questions used in the guides are based on the research question and existing literature, especially focused on embedding external innovation and ambidexterity. The general structure of the interview guides consists of the following sections: Introduction of the interviewers and interviewee, Understanding VCL as a Model, Organizational Embedding, Exploration – Exploitation Dynamics, Success Factors and Challenges, as well as a final Reflection. The interview guides can be found in Appendix A and B.

While there are different types of qualitative interviews, we conducted expert interviews. An expert refers to someone who has specific knowledge about the researched topic that is not commonly available (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). The expert has built that knowledge throughout their career within one or multiple functions. In the case of this research, experts are individuals who are currently working or have spent time working in the venture clienting environment, including positions such as Innovation Leads and Venture Associates. These experts come from the two different groups described above. Using experts from two different

points of view offers multiple perspectives that strengthen the quality of the data and offer the opportunity to highlight different angles on venture clienting.

Most of the conducted interviews were done online via Teams, however in some cases, Zoom and Google Meets were also used. Around one week ahead of the interview, the interviewees received the interview guide and consent form to be able to prepare. While the interview guides led the conversation on, additional questions, opinions, and insights made their way in, adding valuable data to the research. During the interview, one author was the main interviewer, asking the questions; however, with the opportunity for the second author to give further comments and questions. Overall, we tried to give a comfortable setting and give the interviewee room to speak freely and share their honest opinions. A detailed overview of the conducted interviews with the corporate view can be found in Table 1 below.

Case	Name	Industry	Role	VC Maturity	Third-Party Support	Length
1	Scania AB	Automotive	Principal Innovation Lead	**Advanced** (structured, centralized, dedicated roles)	**Yes** (Ongoing)	55:46
2	Karls Oy*	Industrial Manufacturing	Head of Innovation Execution	**Intermediate** (formal process, scaling phase ongoing)	**No explicit external VC partner**	46:13
3	Lumera*	Banking / Finance	AI Product & Project Consultant	**Intermediate** (decentralized, project-driven)	**No** (Just in the beginning)	48:23
4	Lufthansa Innovation Hub	Aviation	Venture Clienting Manager	**Advanced** (dedicated unit + standardized process)	**No**	50:47
5	HELM AG	Chemicals / Distribution	Co-Lead Venture Clienting	**Early-Intermediate** (built governance and multiple success cases)	**Yes** (Ongoing)	51:29
6	Teknor SE*	Chemicals / Materials	New Business Development Manager	**Early** (recent implementation of VCL)	**Yes** (Ongoing)	37:33

7	Alpha Corp AB*	Industrial	Business Development Lead	**Early-Intermediate** (informal, no VC label/process)	**Yes** (Ongoing)	27:38
8	Metron AG*	Manufacturing	Technology & Startup Scout	**Intermediate-Advanced** (established unit, but low integration rate)	**Yes** (selective and flexible use)	47:53
9	Köster GmbH	Construction	Senior Venture Manager	**Early** (just started building the unit)	**No**	50:06
10	Sovian AG*	Energy	Venture Clienting Manager	**Intermediate-Advanced** (strategically integrated)	**Yes** (Ongoing)	38:04
-	Everta AB*	Consumer Goods	Venture Architect	**Intermediate** (regional VCL activities, not fully unified)	**No information**	33:26

Table 1: Interviews Cases

Companies marked with a star * were anonymized according to their wishes by using cover names and slightly adjusted information.

As shown above, the case organizations come from a wide variety of industries, offering different perspectives as industry- related particularities potentially shape the way VCL works and the problems that are being solved by it.

The roles of the interviewees differ; however, we were mostly offered the opportunity to speak with the head of the VCU. In the Consumer Goods interview, the person interviewed is not active in Venture Clienting but in other Corporate Venture activities such as CVC and Venture Building, which led to the decision not to use that firm as a case per se but rather as a supporting angle. Due to her contact with the VCU, the interviewee offered valuable insights from her side of innovation management, especially in terms of how other venture vehicles and venture clienting may interact with each other. The VCL maturity was determined by the combination of the following factors: time of VCL implementation, performed pilots and adoptions, and strategic integration.

At the time of the study, there was a limited number of consultancies or service providers (SP) that specifically named their service according to the venture client model. SP-A and SP-B are two of the most well-known and named, according to the interviews, while SP-C holds a rather small role. To stay within the scope of a master's thesis, we decided to limit the frame to three of these firms and not interview further ones. A detailed overview of the interviews conducted with the six service providers can be found below in Table 2.

The following table shows a summary of the interviews performed with the service providers, who were anonymized in the process.

ID	Service Provider (SP)	Role Level	Main Responsibility	Focus Area	Experience with VC	Core Perspective	Length
SP1	A	Senior Consultant	VC implementation & design	Strategy + operations	High (5+ years)	End-to-end VC model	36:51
SP2	A	Venture Associate (Senior)	VC project execution	Pilot & adoption processes	Medium–High	Operational VC execution	62:10
SP3	A	Venture Associate	VC project support	Operations & delivery	Medium	Hands-on VC delivery	38:22
SP4	B	Senior Advisor	Strategic Advisory	VC strategy & ecosystem	High	Conceptual & strategic VC perspective	55:17
SP5	B	Business Development Manager	Corporate engagement	Ecosystem & matchmaking	Medium–High	Corporate-startup collaboration	40:40
SP6	C	Senior Executive	Venture Hub Leadership	VC unit building & governance	High	Organizational setup & scaling	53:41

Table 2: Interviews Service Providers

In total, we were able to collect 7 hours and 34 minutes of interview material from our cases, an additional 33 minutes from the venture architect / CVC perspective, and 4 hours and 47 minutes from the service provider interviews. This adds to a total of 12 hours and 54 minutes from 17 interviews.

3.3.3 Secondary Data and Case Profiles

In addition to the previously described primary data, the study uses secondary textual data for building the cases. To build and support the cases, we made use of their company websites, LinkedIn posts, and possible additional public data.

Based on this secondary data and the primary data collected in the interviews, we present the ten cases as follows:

Case 1: Scania AB

Scania is a Swedish multinational provider of transport solutions. The company employs 50,000 people in over 100 countries. Scania is part of the TRATON Group (Volkswagen) and is acting in a highly competitive and transforming industry which is currently faced with multiple challenges including decarbonization, digitalization, and new market entrants from (Scania, 2026a). One pillar of their strategy is pushing boundaries by building, buying, partnering and investing (Scania, 2026b).

Venture clienting at Scania is embedded within the TRATON R&D Innovation Management department and addresses both product and process innovation challenges (Interview & Combient Foundry, 2025). The company has conducted over 25 pilot projects, of which 11 have been scaled globally, indicating a relatively advanced level of operationalization.

At Scania venture clienting is not the only vehicle for innovation but part of a wider corporate venturing portfolio. Scania operates an internal venture capital unit ("Scania Invest"), engages in venture building, and maintains an innovation factory (Scania, 2026c).

Therefore, the company uses a portfolio-based approach to innovation, combining external sourcing, internal development, and financial investment vehicles. Scania represents a case of an industrial incumbent applying venture clienting within a structured and multi-layered corporate venturing ecosystem.

Case 2: Karls Oy*

Karls is a Finnish multinational in the elevator industry, employing over 55,000 people in nearly 60 countries. The company's strategy focuses on digital transformation, sustainability, and modernization of existing infrastructure.

Venture clienting activities at Karls are embedded within broader innovation team structures and are mainly externally known through participation in a Venture Clienting Alliance. However, the practice is not always explicitly called venture clienting within the organization.

In terms of corporate venturing activities, Karls does not operate a corporate venture capital unit but instead highlighted the acquisitions of high-growth companies for accessing external innovation.

Karls represents a case where venture clienting is applied within an innovation function but is not institutionalized as a standalone or formally branded approach.

Case 3: Lumera*

Lumera is a German state bank, employing around 12,500 people and operating in 21 countries. The organization is publicly owned and focuses on sustainability and transformation within the financial sector.

Venture clienting was introduced in 2023 and is now a decentralized approach embedded within project groups rather than a dedicated unit. Its primary objective is to improve efficiency and integrate new technologies into existing processes while minimizing risk.

Due to them being a bank, they do not engage in CVC but have their own financially motivated venture capital unit.

Lumera represents a case of decentralized and efficiency-driven venture clienting adoption, with limited integration into a broader corporate venturing system within a distinct industry.

Case 4: Lufthansa Innovation Hub

The Lufthansa Innovation Hub (LHIH) is a subsidiary of the Lufthansa Group and works as an independent GmbH within the global airline corporation that employs around 100,000 people (Lufthansa Group, 2026a). The Lufthansa Group pursues a strategy focused on

customer-centricity, operational excellence, and long-term transformation in a rapidly evolving mobility ecosystem (Lufthansa Group, 2026b). LHIH acts as a dedicated interface between the corporate core and emerging innovation opportunities (LHIH, 2026a).

LHIH is an innovation unit that identifies technologies and market shifts and translates them into new business opportunities (LHIH LinkedIn, 2026). Venture clienting, done by the "Startup Gate" unit, was introduced approximately two years ago and complements other innovation activities (Interview).

Venture clienting at LHIH is embedded within a broader corporate venturing architecture. This includes venture building, strategic intelligence, and transformation units, as well as corporate venture capital activities, although the last has become less relevant due to economic conditions (LHIH, 2026b).

Overall, LHIH represents a comparatively mature and ecosystem-embedded case, where venture clienting is integrated into a broader corporate innovation approach.

Case 5: HELM AG

HELM AG is a German family-owned chemical distribution company founded in 1900, operating in over 30 countries with business units in chemicals, crop solutions, and energy materials (HELM, 2026a). The company has recently undergone a strategic renewal emphasizing sustainability, partnerships, and long-term transformation.

Venture clienting is implemented through the unit "HELM Horizon," launched approximately one year ago and positioned within corporate development, focusing f. ex. on sustainability, circular economy and process excellence topics (LinkedIn HELM, 2025).

HELM is in the early stages of building a broader corporate venturing architecture. While venture clienting currently serves as the primary vehicle for accessing external innovation, the company is actively exploring the introduction of corporate venture capital activities soon (Interview).

HELM represents a transformation-driven case in which venture clienting functions as an entry point into a broader corporate innovation system.

Case 6: Teknor SE*

Teknor is a German manufacturer of adhesive solutions with approximately 4,500 employees and operations in 15 countries. The company pursues a strategy strongly focused on sustainability and innovation.

Venture clienting has been introduced recently and is embedded within the new business development function under the CTO (Interview). The initiative aims to structure startup collaboration more systematically and to complement existing innovation efforts. In terms of corporate venturing, Teknor engages in M&A activities but not in corporate venture capital.

Teknor represents a case that just started venture clienting to focus on formalizing previously unstructured startup collaboration practices.

Case 7: Alpha Corp AB*

Alpha Corp is a Swedish industrial equipment manufacturer and a large company in Sweden founded in the 19th century. The firm employs around 60,000 people in more than 62 countries. The company focuses on innovation-driven growth, particularly in areas such as energy efficiency and connectivity.

While Alpha Corp has engaged with venture clienting through a bigger VCL network, the concept does not appear to be fully formalized internally. Instead, the company relies more strongly on acquisitions, often acquiring companies fully rather than engaging in minority investment structures (Interview).

Venture clienting appears to play a more exploratory or externally facilitated role rather than being deeply embedded as a core organizational process in this case.

Case 8: Metron AG*

Metron is a German family-owned manufacturer of domestic appliances, employing over 20,000 people. The company emphasizes sustainability and product quality.

Corporate venturing activities are centralized within a dedicated unit: a venture house established in 2018 that combines venture clienting, venture capital, venture building, and other entrepreneurship programs (Interview).

Venture clienting is therefore embedded within an integrated and multi-modal innovation system, sometimes interacting with other vehicles such as corporate venture capital and

internal venture development. However, the importance of CVC has decreased in recent years. Metron represents one of the most comprehensive corporate venturing setups in the sample, where venture clienting is fully integrated into a broader strategic innovation architecture.
Case 9: Köster GmbH Köster is a German construction and engineering company with approximately 2,250 employees (Köster Bau, 2026a). The company is characterized by lean processes and short decision-making paths. Corporate venturing activities are managed through "Köster Ventures," a very recently established unit located directly under the CEO (LinkedIn Köster Ventures, 2026 & Interview). The unit combines venture clienting, venture capital, and venture building, with a strong focus on process innovation. Köster thus represents an early stage but expected to be a highly integrated corporate venturing setup within a distinct industry.
Case 10: Sovian AG* Sovian is a global energy technology company with approximately 100,000 employees operating in over 90 countries. The company focuses on innovation in renewable energy, grids, and industrial decarbonization. Corporate venturing activities are organized within Sovian Ventures, established in 2020, which combines venture clienting, venture capital, and venture building. Venture clienting was initially located within a global innovation function but has recently been repositioned within the strategy function, increasing its proximity to top management (Interview). Sovian represents a large-scale and strategically integrated corporate venturing system, where venture clienting plays a central role in driving competitiveness and supporting the energy transition.

Table 3: Case Profiles

Companies marked with a star * were anonymized according to their wishes by using cover names and slightly adjusted information.

In addition to the data from the cases and surrounding the cases, we used secondary data to triangulate our findings from the interviews. Triangulation means using multiple data sources in order to build a more comprehensive picture of the topic researched, mitigating bias and increasing robustness of the findings (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021).

While there is a need for caution in comparing the realities of the found data, the secondary data offers us deeper insights into our cases but also additional knowledge from other experts, expanding the data that our findings are based on.

The data used most for the triangulation of the findings are LinkedIn posts related to the topic of venture clienting and publicly available news articles and reports. For that, an internet and LinkedIn search was conducted by using keywords such as “venture clienting”, “venture client”, VCL and CVC”, “Venture clienting future”, “Venture clienting and ambidexterity”, “Venture clienting today”, “Why venture clienting”, “Successful venture clienting”.

Person / Entity	Company	Relation to VCL	Post date
Gregor Gimmy	27PILOTS / Deloitte	Global Lead for Venture Client Solutions	Mar 2025
Prof. Dr. Tobias Gutmann	EBS Universität für Wirtschaft und Recht	Author of the book “Venture Clienting”	Dec 2025
VCIInstitute	VCIInstitute	Publishes and discusses VCL practices	Oct 2024
Nico Heby	Ekipa	Works with VCL	n.d.
Kim Moore	Global Corporate Venturing	Editor of Global University Venturing and deputy editor of Global Corporate Venturing and produces video for the website	Jan 2026
Sabine VanderLinden	Alchemy Crew Ventures	CEO & Venture-Client Partner	Jul 2024
Elmar Hackmann	Worldiety	Publishing on Corporate Venturing	Dec 2025

Gregor Gimmy & Sebastian Schäfer	27Pilots / Deloitte	Global Lead for Venture Client Solutions & Venture Client Solutions Lead	Dec 2024
Greg Ombach	Airbus	Venture portfolio oversight and publishing on venture clienting	Mar 2023
Alice Repetti	HITS - House of Insurtech Switzerland	Works with innovation	Aug 2025

Table 4: Secondary Data Profiles

3.4 Data Analysis

Analysing qualitative data can be separated into three approaches: deductive, inductive and abductive. For this paper, the abductive data analysis is most fitting as it allows for us to iteratively move between theory and data, redefining concepts as patterns emerge from the interviews. This way, we can adapt and extent existing frameworks based on the data collected.

There is a variety of approaches to frame and interpret qualitative data including for example, content analysis, grounded analysis and thematic analysis (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). All of these methods serve different research aims and ways of making sense of qualitative data. In terms of this research, thematic analysis was used to systematically identify, analyze and interpret recurring patterns and underlying mechanisms within the qualitative data allowing a deeper understanding of how VCL practices shape organizational processes and outcomes. Braun and Clarke (2006) conceptualize thematic analysis through the following steps:

The initial phase consists of the transcription of the data and familiarization with it. This includes rereading the data actively while already searching for meaning and patterns, which can be a first indicator for choosing the right codes. The transcription of our conducted interviews happened simultaneously with the online interviews through Teams. As two interviews were not done with teams, the transcripts were generated through an AI-powered tool called Turboscribe. These transcripts were then carefully proofread and, in some cases, translated with the help of AI (DeepL). During this phase, we did a within-case analysis to understand the organizational context, venture clienting setup, strategic goals, and mechanisms that enabled a first identification of company-specific patterns and structures before going into cross-case analysis. During this phase, AI was also used to help gather quotes from transcripts.

After this initial phase, the generation of initial codes follows. Braun and Clarke (2006) describe codes as "a feature of the data that appears interesting to the analyst". The long list of codes from phase 2 is then the base for developing themes and patterns in phase 3. The codes will be sorted into potential themes and possibly reveal overarching patterns. During these two phases, we started the cross-case analysis where we systematically compared patterns, similarities, and differences across the cases.

In phase 4, the themes will be reviewed and refined, which can lead to the removal or creation of new themes. This is done by rereading the data to ascertain whether the themes fit the data and to possibly recode missing data from earlier stages. Then, the themes are finalized by defining and naming them as well as conceptualizing the research through the "interpretation of keywords, codes and themes" (Naeem et al., 2023).

Naeem et al. (2023) complement Braun and Clarke's 6-phase framework and describe the last phase in the thematic analysis as the "Development of a conceptual model". While demonstrating the "sufficient evidence of the themes within the data" (Braun & Clarke, 2006), Naeem et al. (2023) emphasize analyzing the data through the guidance of existing theories, which aligns with our previously discussed use of methods. This last step is where we are able to derive both practical implications and also contribute to and build new theory as described previously (Eisenhardt, 1989).

The following figure shows our adaptation of Naeem et al.'s (2023) complementation of Braun and Clarkes (2023) framework, which we followed for our thematic analysis. For simplification reasons, steps one and two are summarized in the first column, represented by quotations.

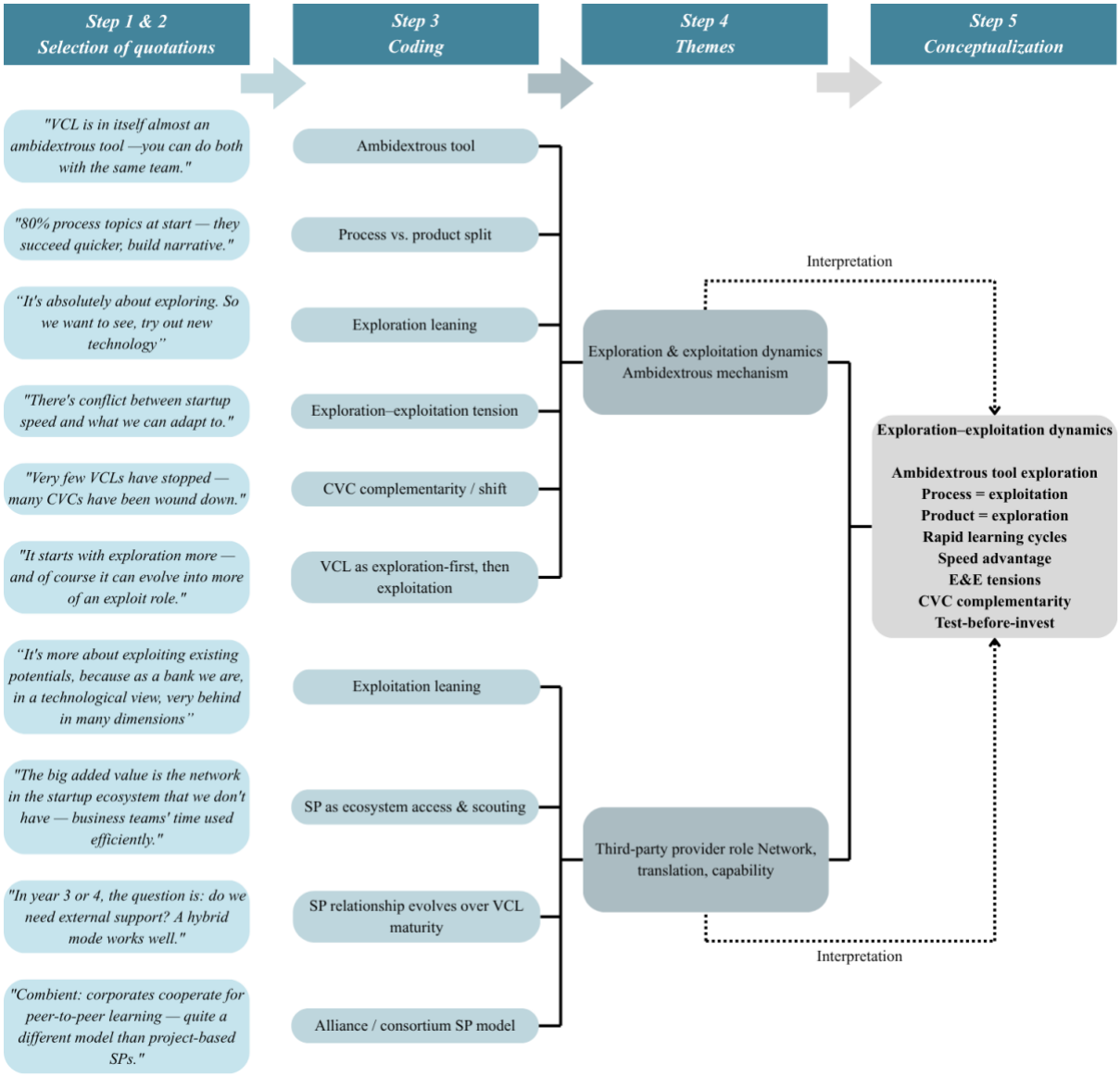


Figure 3: Exemplary Thematic Analysis Process for Exploration-Exploitation Dynamics (Based on Naeem et al., 2023, p.4)

For visual help, we created a thematic map, showing an overview of all codes and themes and how they are related to each other (Braun & Clarke, 2006). This map was developed throughout multiple stages, starting with the initial thematic map, leading to the final thematic map with the main themes. While the figure above shows part of that map, the full version can be found in **Appendix C:** Coding Map.

3.5 Research Quality

To assure quality within our research, we followed the four aspects of trustworthiness defined by Guba (1981): Credibility, Transferability, Dependability, and Confirmability. These criteria enable us to evaluate the data and ensure robustness and transparency.

Credibility addresses the accurate representation of participants' perspectives and the studied phenomenon (Guba, 1981). It looks at how well the results correspond with reality. To enhance credibility, we relied on established qualitative methods and clearly outlined both our methodological approach and theoretical foundation. Furthermore, we engaged deeply with the research context of venture clienting by building a comprehensive understanding through existing literature, company information, and ongoing engagement with the topic via online platforms such as LinkedIn. During data collection, we applied an interviewing approach where we followed our interview guide but added follow-up questions. Triangulation played a central role in strengthening credibility. We combined multiple data sources, including our semi-structured interviews conducted with corporate experts and service providers, as well as secondary data such as company websites, LinkedIn posts, and publicly available reports. This allowed us to cross-check insights and validate interpretations. In addition, we continuously compared emerging findings with existing theory, following an abductive logic, which further reinforced the plausibility and consistency of our results.

Secondly, **Transferability** describes the extent to which findings can be applied to other contexts. To support this, we used purposive sampling to capture multiple and diverse perspectives across different organizations and actors involved in VCL, aligning with Guba's (1981) idea. Moreover, we provide a detailed description of our research context and the different cases used for the multiple-case study. This "thick description" then enables the readers to evaluate the degree of fittingness between contexts and determine whether the findings can be transferred.

Third, **Dependability** concerns the consistency and transparency of the research process that enables future repetition of the study, which is, however, difficult in qualitative studies due to the dynamic nature of social contexts (Shenton, 2004). We therefore followed Shenton's (2004) suggested approach to closely describe research design and its execution, the details of data collection, and lastly to reflect on the research approach used within this paper.

Lastly, **Confirmability** relates to the objectivity of the researcher and how findings are shaped by participants rather than the researchers' bias. Here, we can again refer to triangulation due to the collection of data from different perspectives and origins. Additionally, this data was most of the time collected by both authors together and always analyzed in tandem, allowing for cross-checking interpretations and coding decisions.

3.6 Research Ethics

Ethical considerations are fundamental in qualitative research, particularly when engaging directly with participants and organizational contexts. As highlighted by Easterby-Smith et al. (2021), ethical awareness is closely related to how researchers engage with participants and the research setting, requiring careful handling and reflection throughout the research process. As we had strong interviewee engagement throughout our multiple-case study, we followed the key principles in research ethics according to Bell & Bryman (2007). We especially focused on the following to protect both the study's participants' interests and ours' as researchers: Informed Consent, Confidentiality and Anonymity, Avoidance of Harm, Affiliation and Reciprocity.

To assure **Informed Consent**, all participants were provided with clear information regarding the purpose of the study, the scope of the research, and how the collected data would be used ahead of time. Participation was entirely voluntary, and explicit consent was obtained before each interview through the university's GDPR consent form. Participants were also informed of their right to withdraw from the study at any stage. This ensured that participation was based on transparency and mutual understanding.

Given the corporate context of venture clienting and the potential sensitivity of shared information, **Confidentiality** and **Anonymity** were highly relevant. Participants were allowed to decide how much information would be published about them and their case within the case descriptions and the analysis. Therefore, we followed the wishes to remove identifiable details such as names, roles, or company-specific information where necessary. All interviewees' names, however, were anonymized from the beginning. This allowed participants to speak openly about internal processes and experiences without risking reputational or organizational consequences. Data was solely stored on our private laptops and the university's OneDrive, assuring data protection and no access for anyone but the researchers and supervisor.

The research design was developed to **Avoid Harm** to participants. Interview questions focused on professional experiences rather than personal or sensitive topics. In addition, care was taken during the reporting of findings to ensure that no statements could be traced back to individuals or used in a way that could negatively affect participants or their organizations.

Transparency regarding the researchers' roles and intentions and possible **Affiliations** was maintained throughout the study. Participants were clearly informed that the research was conducted for academic purposes within the context of a master's thesis. No misleading information about the study's objectives or outcomes was provided, ensuring an honest and trustworthy relationship between researchers and participants. This was especially relevant, as one author was working for one of the case organizations at the beginning of the study.

In line with ethical research practice, we aimed to establish a mutually beneficial relationship with participants, displaying the principle of **Reciprocity**. Participants were offered insights into the research outcomes upon completion of the study. This approach acknowledges participants' contributions and supports knowledge exchange between academia and practice. This aligns with a general pattern within the venture clienting environment, which shows deep interest in exchanges between actors and the aspiration to move the topic from operations further into the academic world.

4 Findings & Analysis

In this section, the empirical findings from the multi-case study are presented. This chapter gives a whole picture of the VCL process, its contribution to organizational ambidexterity, and the embedding mechanisms needed for effective venture clienting. Additionally, the findings related to the role of the service providers and the maturity effect will be unveiled.

4.1 Definition of Venture Clienting and its Process

While the interviewees come from different industries, positions, organizational structures, and even different angles (corporate vs. service provider), there seems to be a common understanding of what venture clienting is and how it should be defined. A general consensus is that VCL is a non-equity approach to external innovation in which corporations collaborate with startups, taking on the role of an early customer rather than investors or co-developers. In contrast to CVC, venture clienting does not focus on acquiring ownership stakes but instead aims at accessing, piloting, and implementing innovative startup solutions within the organization. SP 4 described it as "starting a business relationship with an early startup to benefit from the solution without taking equity".

This perception was shared across nearly all interviews. Instead of investing financially into startups, companies want to access new technologies in a fast and comparatively low-risk way, which SP 3 summarized by saying "venture clienting buys and tests". Not only the service providers but also the case experts support this idea. The interviewee from Teknor highlights the faster availability of existing solutions rather than having to develop them by themselves. This aligns with the common addressing of the practical and implementation-oriented nature of VCL and its focus on operational impact. The representative of LH Innovation Hub described venture clienting as particularly attractive as "it creates measurable impact, comes at cheap price comparably and it's fast".

Another factor often named is venture clienting as a response to increasing uncertainty, rising innovation pressure, and limited internal resources without the need for internal capability building (Köster).

Overall, the consensus lies within a definition that describes venture clienting as an implementation-oriented external innovation vehicle that allows corporations to access startup innovation while maintaining flexibility and minimizing risk. This definition is further agreed upon by other professionals working with venture clienting. Many, including VanderLinden (2024), describe it similarly: *"*Venture clienting is a corporate innovation model where companies become early customers of startups, purchasing their products without taking equity stakes*"*.

There is similarly a shared opinion and execution among the experts concerning the venture clienting process, both from the service providers who are consulting the firms on the "optimal" process, but also from the case corporations. The venture clienting process was mostly described as a structured and problem-oriented approach that typically consists of four main phases: identifying organizational challenges, scouting and evaluating startups, testing the solutions through pilot projects, and finally integrating the chosen solution into the organization.

Generally, across cases, the process starts with a step often called "problem identification", which describes the act of identifying a specific organizational challenge, inefficiency, or unmet need within the company that cannot be solved in-house within the same budget or timeline. Interviewees repeatedly highlighted that VCL is most of the time not driven by searching for startups first, but rather by clearly defining the business problem, which was clearly stated by service provider 1: "The process always starts with a problem." Similarly, his colleague explains that venture clienting often jumps in when internal capabilities or existing suppliers are unable to adequately solve the problem on hand (SP 3). Most cases, however, mentioned the "push" and "pull" principles: While the previously described problem identification is considered the pull mechanism, as problems are pulled in, push means actively introducing interesting startups and/or their solutions into the organization. LH Innovation Hub explained: "If I were to start a venture client unit again, I would certainly start with push cases rather than pull cases", as they can create visibility and demonstrate impact internally, which was also supported by the interviewee from HELM. Sovian highlights that they "work [more] with the pull model than the push model. Problems usually come to us."

Secondly, once the problem is clearly defined, the process goes into identifying startups that may offer suitable solutions. This phase typically includes ecosystem screenings, startup

benchmarking, demo sessions, and the creation of longlists and shortlists (LH Innovation Hub). As highlighted by Teknor, venture clienting enabled the company to gain a more comprehensive overview of relevant startup ecosystems rather than relying on occasional encounters at startup fairs or events. Many of the case corporations mentioned that this phase is often supported by service providers offering expertise and ecosystem access.

Based on the decision made after the demo sessions, a solution is bought, sometimes mentioned as the "buy" phase, and then piloted. Within these pilots, several interviewees, but especially the service providers highlighted the relevance of fast pilot projects as they consider them to be low-risk opportunities to test startup solutions under real operational conditions before committing to larger implementations. Multiple case experts described piloting not only as a technological validation but also an organizational learning phase to evaluate how solutions fit existing structures and workflows (Alpha Corp).

Once proven successful, the next step was described as integrating the startup solution into broader organizational processes and scaling its usage across the company. This last phase was repeatedly named as the most important as it decides over success and impact. Teknor described it as "you really have to scale it […] you can't stop with piloting". It was highlighted multiple times that venture clienting only generates real business impacts when startup solutions move beyond isolated pilots, showing how adoption and scaling are perceived as critical success factors for creating genuine organizational benefit.

Köster summarized the process as follows:

"The process starts with strategic fields and pain points, then goes into scouting — a long list, short list, follow-ups — then a POC in a protected environment with real data, before moving to piloting and implementation. The most important foundation is first building the internal network to get real pain points." (Köster)

Overall, the interviews show a strong alignment in how venture clienting is understood and executed across both corporates and service providers. Respondents consistently perceive VCL as a structured process with the goal of implementing external solutions into the organization while keeping risk low. While the names and sub-processes may vary in some cases, the core of each phase seems to persist.

Additional Quotes can be found in **Appendix D:** Additional Quotes Definition of Venture Clienting and its Process.

4.2 Organizational Embedding: Anchoring, Culture, and Governance

This section unveils how VCL is often positioned and sustained inside established corporations. Furthermore, the role of top management support and organizational culture affects the efficiency of VCL, which is further explained here. Additionally, this research found internal communication and stakeholder management and engagement as a vital aspect for a successful VCL process, which is explained in this section.

4.2.1 Structural Positioning

Structural variance among the corporate cases participating in the research was considerable. The answers often reflected the organization's specific broader innovation architecture rather than intentional venture client unit-specific design choices.

At Karls, the innovation execution team manages VCL activities, which are part of the broader product development and technology functions, supported by employees dedicated specifically to innovation projects. Metron's venture clienting team is anchored within the digitalization department under the technical management: *"*Because we are part of the technical division, our perspective is naturally very technology-focused*"*. They, however, also have their own "venture house". HELM's venture clienting unit is placed in the corporate development department, as the company does not have a classical R&D due to its business model.

Meanwhile, Lumera began with a centralized VCL team; however, later the responsibility was decentralized across business unit-embedded project managers:

"It's not really a specific venture clienting unit anymore — it's more decentralised now. We experienced that it's not necessary to have it centralised. Make-or-buy decisions exist in every part of the company. Being decentralised means being more embedded in business departments." (Lumera)

Through all the cases examined, it is evident that there is no dedicated department where the venture clienting team or activities would need to be placed. Rather, the conditions and core

business affect the decision where the unit will be anchored. However, patterns were emerging across all the cases. Venture clienting units were anchored below a C-level executive, closely adjacent or embedded into the core business of the organization, equipped with a well-documented and standardized process: Aspects making the process more effective and resilient over time. As an experienced third-party interviewee expressed it:

"It really is a case-by-case basis. It helps if it's not too far from the executive — either the CTO or the chief strategy officer. There's no one-size-fits-all answer. It really depends on the company." (Service Provider 5)

Additional Quotes can be found in **Appendix E**: Additional Quotes Structural Positioning.

4.2.2 The Role of Management Support and Culture

A consistently described enabling factor for effective VCL activities was an innovation-receptive organizational culture. This finding was also supported by other VCL specialists. Gregor Gimmy and Sebastian Schäfer (2024) wrote: *"*Developing a culture that embraces startup innovation, and a willingness to adopt new solutions is essential for the model's success*"*.

However, participants of the study emphasized that VCL can be started with only a small team of motivated "internal champions" without a major prior culture shift.

"You just need a business owner who's convinced about it and some relatively senior people in the company. That's the beauty of venture clienting, to really get some first success you don't need too much. Then you can further build your structures." (Service Provider 5)

However, scaling and institutionalizing VCL is substantially easier within a culture that values experimentation, where failure is tolerated, and where external solutions are not resisted.

"No one wants to be told that what they're doing is a bad job. People need to adopt the solution, not the solution winning on its own. Everyone should feel like part of the solution, not the problem. 'I found this great solution to my own problem', that should be the mentality." (Service Provider 5)

A phenomenon emerging in the interviews repeatedly was the 'Not Invented Here' issue. The not invented here issue was described as internal resistance from employees to external

innovations. For example, Karls' representative explained: "There is a kind of resistance, business units feeling that things are happening outside their control. That is probably one form of not-invented-here." However, interview participants considered this cultural challenge to be generally easy to manage.

To avoid such resistance, venture clienting projects are often complementary rather than competing with internal work. Therefore, an essential aspect in most venture clienting projects is proper framing, as otherwise the project can be considered as a threat to the employees' efforts. As SP 4 explained: "It's really hard to have a project with a startup if the startup is substituting some internal work. Nobody would like that."

The interviews also revealed changes in companies' internal attitudes and culture regarding venture clienting over time. At Scania, employees were not aware that utilizing startups' innovations was permitted. Nowadays, venture clienting has become an established practice within the company's operations, especially through accumulating success stories that have evident tangible value in collaborating with external partners. In the interviews, it appeared that success stories have a clear positive impact on the change in attitudes within the company.

Teknor SE explained the importance of success stories:

"At the end of the day you need to generate impact. It needs to be a business relevant problem, cost savings or additional revenue. If not, no one will take you serious. Impact generation is important because if not, we should not spend any time or money on that." (Teknor)

The venture clienting changing the organizational culture claim is also supported by the broader professionals working with venture clienting. The 2024 State of Venture Client Report (27pilots/Deloitte) found that one in four organizations with a venture client unit reported high satisfaction regarding the impact on the company's culture. Supporting the claim that the organizational culture can be changed with a venture client unit, and it can work as a driver for it.

At the same time, top management support was identified as important; however, it is not always sufficient on its own. Several interviews revealed that the CEO's or general C-level's endorsement provides initial legitimacy.

SP 4 further explained the importance of C-level support:

"You should have a strong mandate from top management; it's still a long-term game. You have a portfolio strategy; not every pilot will become a winner. You have to have the possibility to do several projects and pick the right ones to go further." (Service Provider 4)

However, middle-layer managers, especially in procurement, IT, and legal, can become bottlenecks in the adoption phase of the process. As an example, in one of the companies, top management endorsed venture clienting in principle; however, it withheld active promotion until tangible results were demonstrated. As a result, the innovation team was in a constant position of having to validate its value before securing organizational backing.

Through evidence from all the cases, it can be concluded that one might not want to view the culture and management support as binary prerequisites. Rather, they are dynamic conditions that can be nurtured through conscious communication, visible success, and proper organizational anchoring.

Additional Quotes can be found in **Appendix F:** Additional Quotes The Role of Management Support and Culture.

4.2.3 Internal Communication and Stakeholder Management

Stakeholder management emerged as one of the most essential operational competencies for effective venture clienting. As Lumera put it: "Most important is stakeholder commitment, the hardest to get". Furthermore, the venture clienting manager's role was described as simultaneously diplomatic and entrepreneurial by the interviewees. The manager's job might include identifying problems, building trust within the company, managing expectations with startups, and navigating internally with supporting functions, including IT, legal, and procurement. This is an important aspect as the unit's survival depends on continuous problem inflow. It was described as problem pipelines dry up without proper stakeholder management and engagement, which results in the venture client unit losing its organizational relevance.

Handling problem owner relationships consistently appeared as a critical internal aspect to manage. Business unit managers owning the problem are encouraged to remain engaged throughout the entire process, not only in the problem definition phase. In case of the problem owner changing role or deprioritizing the project, the venture clienting pilot loses its internal anchor, potentially resulting in improbable adaptation.

SP 3 Explains the importance of problem owner engagement:

"It also creates a great ownership for the problem owner. So your projects are not left hanging and you don't have to push them through, but the problem owner takes the steering wheel and actually owns what's going on and engages with the startup. The relationships are way stronger and then it's so much easier to scale." (Service Provider 3)

Systematic internal communication strategies were adopted by several organizations to build awareness and maintain required problem pipelines. This finding is also supported by other experts working with VCL. For example, Greg Ombach (2023) highlights the importance of establishing clear communication channels between the venture client unit and other business units to get startups acquainted with the culture, processes, and policies.

Metron held internal fairs to sustain visibility and utilized internal newsletters to build awareness within the organization. Similarly, in the first year, Lumera invested heavily in building awareness through running 'startup champion' programs, internal events, and educating business departments on what startups actually are, how they operate, and the main difference in working with them compared to working with established vendors.

Lumera's representative explained:

"*We did in the first year nearly just marketing and communication. We shared knowledge that start-ups are not only three people in a garage but can be a company with 40-50 employees and a real tangible solution. It was kind of hard, I don't think even now everyone in this bank thinks startups are worthwhile."* (Lumera)

Similarly, the LH Innovation Hub utilized ambassadors across different group entities, creating an internal VCL advocate network.

Procurement, IT, and legal functions were repeatedly mentioned as bottlenecks that stakeholder management might need to address. Several interviewees highlighted procurement processes, such as supplier evaluation criteria and data processing agreements, as detrimental to speed and the exploratory nature of VCL pilots. Karls' representative explained the difficulty of getting IT architects involved in the process early enough to avoid late-stage integration failures. Scania's representative, on the other hand, spoke of deliberately scoping pilots below

procurement thresholds, which enables speed; however, it can potentially create complexity in the adoption phase.

Additional Quotes can be found in **Appendix G:** Additional Quotes Internal Communication and Stakeholder Management.

4.3 Ambidexterity and Venture Clienting

After introducing the VCL embedding mechanisms, this section unveils the empirical findings related to organizational ambidexterity and VCL. The findings suggest that VCL has the potential to greatly contribute to OA. However, it is also acknowledged that initially companies tend to start with mainly exploitative natured projects, to gain trust and reputation for the VCU.

4.3.1 Exploration – Exploitation Balance

The main theoretical motivation in this research is the question of whether venture clienting acts as a vehicle for organizational ambidexterity, meaning enabling exploration of external innovation and exploitation of existing internal capabilities. No interviewee participating in the research positioned VCL as simply an explorative or exploitative tool. The empirical data rather shows that VCL is a model that has the potential to simultaneously cover both orientations. The weight placed on each side, however, depends on the industry, VCU maturity, organization's strategy, and portfolio composition.

Service providers largely agreed on framing VLC as inherently dual in nature, as one of the interviewees put it: "in itself almost an ambidextrous innovation tool". VCL is seen as a vehicle able to serve both organizational efficiency goals and exploratory innovation objectives, which greatly distinguishes it from other innovation vehicles, which are structurally designed to serve only one orientation. Moreover, a third-party interviewee explained seeing venture clienting as always doing both exploitation and exploration, as identifying and accessing external startup solutions represents exploration, and testing and integrating these solutions represents the exploitation side. Other professionals working close to the topic agree that venture clienting has contributions to both exploitation and exploration. Gutmann (Startbase, 2025) explains venture clienting to be a vehicle that "combines operational proximity and technological exploration — without an investment logic, but with a clear value contribution to the strategic

innovation agenda." The VCI Institute (2024) further states that adopting an ambidextrous approach is vital to maximizing the potential of venture clienting.

The views of the case representatives, on the other hand, were divided. The interviewee representing Scania saw VCL as an explorative tool:

"It's absolutely about exploring. So we want to see, try out new technology. If we already master the technology ourselves, we don't need to do anything like that". (Scania)

In contrast, Lumera's representative described VCL as nearly entirely exploitation-oriented:

"It's more about exploiting existing potentials, because as a bank we are, in a technological view, very behind in many dimensions. So, we don't need to really explore new things, because we are not ready to do that". (Lumera)

Between these extremes, interviewees described a VCL portfolio that usually starts process and efficiency focused, closer to exploitation orientation, which gradually expands towards exploratory projects as the venture client unit matures. Furthermore, nearly all interview participants agreed venture clienting to serve as a tool for both exploitation and exploration, but the way it is used depends on the organization's current problem portfolio. As HELM's representative explained: "Venture clienting is the perfect equilibrium of ambidexterity, because it actually does both, you explore and exploit at the same time".

Additional Quotes can be found in **Appendix H:** Additional Quotes Exploration-Exploitation Balance and Venture Clienting.

4.3.2 The Pull Towards Exploitation

Despite VCL having a theoretical potential to span both exploitation and exploration, the empirical evidence gathered from interviews reveals a systematic gravitation towards exploitation-proximate problem types. Most corporate cases participating in the research are focusing on process related to topics, including AI for sales productivity, logistics efficiency, HR tooling, and procurement analytics, and outnumber product-embedded innovations in their active VCL portfolio.

Process innovations can be attractive for VCL projects because they produce measurable, near-term business cases. These characteristics tend to satisfy internal approval requirements, which

support the unit's longevity. SP 1 explains that when organizations start VCL operations, initially, the project portfolio is approximately 80% process and 20% product.

"Most of the time it starts with 80% process topics, maybe 20% product. Process topics are more likely to succeed quickly and can be used to help create the narrative to further grow. Over time it can balance a bit more." (Service Provider 1)

Another aspect making process innovations possibly more attractive is that they are considered organizationally less threatening. Process innovations strive to improve existing workflows without challenging established product ownership structures, technical competencies, or internal team mandates. Therefore, these types of innovations can reduce the likelihood of 'Not Invented Here' resistance within the organization.

As the interviewee from Sovian explained:

"We do more exploit than explore, because we have an innovation function that should do more of the exploration. We are about exploiting already existing knowledge in a different way. We always focus on process topics — that is the low-hanging fruit. Product is difficult because that is what we sell". (Sovian)

The 2024 State of Venture Client Report (27pilots/Deloitte) further supports the empirical findings by confirming that the most common venture clienting problem types are in the field of process exploitation, while product-based innovations remain smaller.

The third aspect making process innovations popular is VCL's speed logic. The VCL model has a high emphasis on fast validation and lightweight pilots, which can be easier to achieve with process innovations. These types of innovations enable fast deployment and measurable impact and are often more straightforward. Karls' representative described their choice of leaning more towards exploitation:

"*Process innovations, like AI for customer service, are primarily in the exploitation category. There's a conflict between the startup's speed and what we can adapt to. Product innovations take several years and require R&D integration"*. (Karls)

Altogether, the above-listed reasons can make process-related exploitation-natured projects more attractive. Still, venture clienting has the potential to serve as a tool for both exploitation

and exploration, but the choice comes down to the needs of the organization and its problem portfolio.

Additional Quotes can be found in **Appendix I:** Additional Quotes The Pull Towards Exploitation.

4.3.3 Interaction with Internal R&D

Across all interviews, the relationship between VCL and internal R&D departments was described as complementary. However, several interviewees acknowledged the potential for conflicts when startup solutions are perceived as competing with internal R&D's work. How VCL is perceived within the organization can depend on how VCL is anchored in the organization and how the collaboration is communicated internally. When VCL is anchored within or closely adjacent to internal R&D, the unit tends to work as a scouting arm for the broader research organization within the company. Here, VCL identifies commercially ready solutions or problems that would consume too many resources if developed internally.

The interviewee from Teknor SE explained how VCL is used to support internal R&D:

"We maybe don't have the capability, or it took too long to ramp up this kind of capability. And that's the reason why venture clienting came in without any upfront investment. We decided, OK, let's just look into the ecosystem, if there's a solution, just buy a product or service which already exists, just to try it and then see if we can integrate it within the company." (Teknor)

Such strategic support emerged in nearly every interview. Another interviewee, Sovian's representative, further explained the importance of VCL supporting internal R&D efforts to help the company remain competitive:

"There's so much money invested in the startup ecosystem every year and if we're really going to benefit, we need to tap into it differently because we'll never be able to compete using only our own R&D". (Sovian)

A consistent design principle emerged across all the cases participating in the research. To have a productive VCL – R&D relationship, the responsibilities of each entity might need to be clearly defined. VCL's function is to scout externally, and R&D focuses on technical development internally. Managing this relationship and boundaries is a form of OA in practice, as it simultaneously maintains the exploration and exploitation within the same organization.

Interestingly, the VCI Institute (2024) suggests another potential challenge regarding venture clienting and internal R&D: over-reliance. They point out the importance of balance between venture clienting and internal R&D, as otherwise over-reliance on venture clienting can lead to a decrease in proactive innovation. Therefore, it can be concluded that managing the internal relationship between R&D staff and the venture client unit, while also maintaining strategic balance, is vital for the future relevance of the organization.

Additional Quotes can be found in **Appendix J:** Additional Quotes Interaction with Internal R&D.

4.3.4 Exploratory Applications and the Maturity Effect

Although exploitation orientation was found to be more common in early-stage VCL portfolios, interviews revealed another consistent pattern. When maturing, venture client units tend to shift more towards a balanced mix of both orientations. However, such a maturity effect is not automatic, rather it reflects the intended expansion, which is enabled by strong trust, a successful track record, and the right anchoring of the unit.

Nearly all interview participants agreed that starting with process exploitation is the easiest way as it generates “quick wins”, which builds credibility, trust, and stronger stakeholder relationships. When the VCU has managed to establish itself as a settled corporate unit, it can start to look for more ambitious projects. SP 2 explains:

"*What we can see is, and especially when you are in your early phase of a venture client journey, you need to show quick wins, and you do not show quick wins in the first months with product topics most of the time. In general, process topics are more likely to succeed quickly and can be used to help create the narrative to further grow”*. (Service Provider 2)

Teknor represents the early stage of venture clienting, having only recently established its venture client unit. According to the interviewee, they will initially focus on process exploitation to learn about the process and get quick visible results: "We really need first good results to say, OK, maybe we also need some internal”. However, the interview also revealed that the unit has future product innovation projects in mind, although their time will come at a later stage. Scania’s case, on the other hand, exemplifies one of the more advanced ventures of clienting cases. Initially, VCL projects were purely exploitative in nature. However, over time,

as the unit matured, their attention to explorative projects increased significantly: *"It's absolutely about exploring. So, we want to see, try out new technology"*.

Additional Quotes can be found in **Appendix K:** Additional Quotes Exploratory Applications and the Maturity Effect.

4.4 Venture Clienting and Its Position within Corporate Venturing

After having examined venture clienting as a standalone practice, this section looks at how it fits within the broader corporate venturing landscape. As the findings reveal, VCL seems to be a distinct but complementary vehicle that is liked for its speed and measurable impact while developing potential synergies with tools such as CVC.

4.4.1 Venture Clienting as a Distinct but Complementary Tool

Across the majority of corporate cases, the most prominent current venturing tools are corporate venture capital and venture clienting. This landscape, however, has evolved after a time where venture building was one of the main models used to bring external innovation into the corporates, which can be dated back to the beginning till mid 2010's. While some corporates still use venture building (Everta, Köster, LH Innovation Hub), its limitations were presented by multiple experts within the study. It was frequently described as a resource-intensive approach requiring significant upfront investments and commitments, long development timelines, and a strong need for internal capabilities to successfully launch a venture to the market. This then becomes especially problematic if short-term impact is needed in volatile times, such as right now, as these ventures require years before delivering tangible business value.

At the same time, it is noticeable that venture building is still present in some of the cases; however, it sometimes takes on a different role. While in the consumer goods case, where the venture architect was interviewed, it is still used as the classical tool without intersecting with VCL, the aviation case shows how venture building and VCL can correlate with each other. The interviewee highlights that venture building is used particularly when "there was absolutely no startup out there that could cater to that niche", which relates to the specific requirements of the aviation industry (LH Innovation Hub). This is where both venturing tools

intersect, as this interviewee described. While a problem initially might be approached through VCL, the solving method must be changed to venture building due to the unavailability of any suitable external solutions. This highlights a sequential logic in which VCL acts as a first step in exploring external solutions, while venture building serves as a more "last resort" approach for some.

Altogether, venture clienting was repeatedly framed as a more efficient alternative, especially in environments characterized by cost pressures and a need for faster impacts. One of the service providers noted that while venture building is "super cost intensive", VCL enables firms to achieve "less cost for more potential upside" (SP 1), especially when focusing on solving concrete operational problems. This comparison illustrates this generalizable shift across the cases in corporate priorities from long-term venture creation towards more immediate and measurable impact generation.

This is supported by other interviewees, including SP 3, who emphasized that corporations increasingly seek "efficient" and "cheap" ways to access innovation, particularly in comparison to more resource-intensive approaches such as venture building. Furthermore, this emphasizes the growing preference for models that deliver faster and more tangible impact. The venture architect from Everta described it as follows:

"Is there a startup in the market already doing 80% of what we're looking for? Then there's no point reinventing the wheel — we can say let's partner, invest, or acquire. Or if no one's good enough, we'll just build it ourselves. VCL is one node in a broader decision tree." (Everta)

Overall, the empirical findings indicate that venture building is not necessarily vanishing in some corporations due to a lack of relevance, but rather because of the emergence of more efficient, more structured, and lower-risk alternatives, with venture clienting being the most trending one. This tool has now gained traction as it allows access to external innovation in a more flexible and scalable way. Another aspect seemingly relevant here is the challenge of doing venture building 'correctly'. The interviewee from Teknor pointed out that many corporations have struggled setting up venture building in a structured way, leading to limited impact and difficulties in scaling. This is where experts from both the corporate side and service provider perspective agree that VCL is a highly structured and process-driven approach, which is able to mitigate challenges like that.

There seems to be a similar repositioning for corporate venture capital. While CVC remains widely used, the interviews reveal a growing differentiation on how its role is perceived compared to more operational approaches such as VCL. However, at the same time multiple interviewees observed a broader trend that CVC units are decreasing in number especially among large European industrial corporations.

"The average corporate venture capital fund survives only three and a half years. A lot have cancelled CVC because the results haven't been there. Venture clienting, by contrast — there are very few that have really stopped it. A lot are actually increasing it over time." (Service Provider 5)

This again can be traced back to increasing cost pressure and consolidation measures by the management. One significant proof for that was given by SP 2, who gave insights on how she has seen multiple CVC units close, while at the same time, she is not aware of any VCL units closing. This could lead to the assumption that VCL is substituting CVC, which, however, was declined by several interviewees. Another service provider assesses this in the following manner:

"VCL is not substituting CVC but gains relative prominence because it delivers faster, more measurable operational impact, which makes it more defendable in budget constrained environments." (Service Provider 4)

Broader professional discussion on the topic aligns with our findings. For example, Moore (2026) writes how 49% of CVC teams express engaging in venture clienting in GCV's Keystone survey, indicating that venture clienting indeed is often coupled with CVC.

Across interviews, CVC is associated with an investment- and return-driven logic by gaining equity stakes in startups and generating financial returns. Most often CVC units however seem to lack strategic alignment and therefore have loose ties with the core business.

"CVC cannot build their portfolios to match exactly the strategic needs of the business because that doesn't work from a venture capital perspective. Their pure purpose is literally to make money. What we try to do is solve problems — and that is just the differentiating purpose." (Service Provider 2)

This is where there a fundamental difference can be seen, with a special highlight on financial return versus the company's actual technology needs to solve a specific strategic or operational problem. Supported by SP 5, structural misfit combined with the difficulty of translating CVC investments into direct operational impact, has been named within multiple cases as a driver for closing or never even implementing CVC units (Teknor).

Additional Quotes can be found in **Appendix L:** Additional Quotes Venture Clienting as a Distinct but Complementary Tool.

4.4.2 "Test Before Invest" as a Linking Mechanism

Based on the previously described findings, we could see different patterns of coexistence of venture clienting and corporate venture capital across the cases. However, the overarching agreement was that VCL is rather a complementary tool than a whole substitution for CVC. Scania operates both models at the same time, describing it as a triangular relationship: VCL projects sometimes lead to startups that become candidate for CVC investment, while CVC sometimes identifies investees that become VCL partners. There are similar findings from the aviation case. Here, the interviewee highlights: "I would never invest in a startup without having done venture clienting with them first, because you know exactly how good the product is" (LH Innovation Hub). This view is also supported by a broader audience. For example, venture clienting practitioner Nico Heby (Ekipa) points out:

"If the pilot works and the strategic fit runs deep, that's a stronger basis for CVC investment than any due diligence could produce. You've already seen the team deliver. You know the technology works in your environment." (Ekipa)

This indicates that there seems to be a trend towards a "test-before-invest" logic, which was named by multiple of interviewees:

"Test before you invest — that's one thing we start to hear, and I also start to use it. Most CVCs are not after financial gains — they are strategic investors. And to assess strategic potential, you need to really look: does this work in our business?" (Service Provider 5)

This logic indicates that VCL increasingly acts as an upstream mechanism to reduce uncertainty in investment decisions. Rather than relying solely on traditional due diligence processes, corporates potentially use VCL to generate real-world validation of a startup's

technology, organizational fit, and scalability within their specific context. As mentioned in the aviation case, this procedure allows for a level of insight that cannot be achieved through financial evaluation alone.

A case where CVC is still a prominent and successful tool is the consumer goods case, where a venture architect was interviewed who was not closely involved with VCL itself. Her perspective, however, has underlined this upstanding idea that solutions need to be tested before investments happen. According to her, she is open to further increasing the level of relationship with the VCU, showing open-mindedness from multiple directions concerning this evolving vehicle (Everta).

SP 3 also highlights how this could enable a shift from financially driven CVC units to a higher level of strategic alignment as it allows for assessing whether a solution "actually works in our business". Consequently, VCL not only complements operationally by deepening the level of due diligence but potentially enhances its effectiveness by improving the quality of investment choices.

At the same time, as previously described, there are cases where it also works in the other direction, and CVC supports VCL activities. This mechanism works by providing access to vetted startups and reducing perceived risk (Scania).

"We have a corporate venture capital arm. They help us assess companies from a technical point of view and sometimes we see that we can cooperate with a company and then try to put together a pilot. So, it's a triangle — CVC, VCL, and business — that feed each other." (Scania)

A sense of caution seems to be needed here, as this could create an unintended prioritization of CVC-backed startups despite them not being the best fit for a specific business problem. While these patterns could be seen within a number of cases and found agreement within the service provider's opinions, cases exist where there are barely any synergies between both models (Lumera). Simultaneously, their CVC unit, as well as Metron's, have increasingly been constrained due to the current economic climate, while VCL has maintained its positioning.

Overall, the coexistence of venture clienting and corporate venture capital can be best described as a mutually reinforcing system, at least in cases where these synergies are actively used or

welcomed. In this system, VCL enables experimentation and validation, while CVC allows corporates to secure long-term financial gains and potentially strategic-value, depending on the followed investment strategy.

Additional Quotes can be found in **Appendix M:** Additional Quotes “Test Before Invest” as a Linking Mechanism.

4.5 Scaling Venture Clienting

This section unravels how venture clienting can move beyond isolated pilots to become a repeatable and scalable organizational capability by looking the findings for enablers and complicators in the process. Lastly, the role of external service providers is examined.

4.5.1 Scaling Enablers

While the previous sections have identified structural and cultural factors supporting the implementation of venture clienting, the collected data suggests that scaling VCL and moving past the pilot stage of the process asks for further enabling factors. Rather than generic success factors, these enabling conditions appear to become relevant at later stages, where the future success of VCUs is determined and under pressure.

First, standardization as a mechanism for repeatability seems to be a key enabling factor. This includes everything from a standardized process to templates, governance and routines that reduce friction and make the model operable at scale. Across cases, interviewees highlighted their role in making venture clienting more than individual pilots. For example, the LH Innovation Hub demonstrates this behaviour through dedicated procurement processes, standardized contract templates, and pre-aligned legal interfaces. Similarly, Teknor, an early-stage VCU, highlighted the importance of aligning processes and documents early-on in the process.

Second, venture clienting can sustain attention and be scaled through visible impact and success cases. While this factor was already mentioned previously in 4.2.2, it finds repeated relevance here as success cases not only function as cultural enablers but as an active scaling mechanism that supports replication across the organization. As several interviewees mentioned, sometimes top-down management support is not a sufficient communication tool

to get everyone engaged. This is where successful pilots appear to function as internal proof points that attract additional problem owners and stakeholder support.

"It becomes much easier once you have initial success stories that you can share. Bringing examples from other companies also helps build trust internally and reduces resistance." (Metron)

One service provider described success cases as highly relevant, as it could turn even sceptical actors into "the biggest allies" while also emphasizing how some VCUs actively pitch adopted solutions across departments to diffuse use and build scale. Additionally, as can be seen at Lumera and Metron, the adoption of internal newsletters, startup champion programs, and communication formats can be particularly helpful not only for awareness-building but also as mechanisms to expand venture clienting within the organization, even in later stages.

Lastly, a third scaling enabler emerging across cases is problem-owner commitment. While problem owners have already appeared previously in organizational embedding, the data supports that their role becomes even more critical in scaling venture clienting, especially moving from pilot toward adoption. Multiple interviewees from both sides have highlighted the issue of ownership once a project moves from pilot to adoption. In this case, it is not necessarily a technological issue causing the failure, but rather a combination of factors, including a lack of ownership. At the same time, in cases where problem owners stayed engaged, provided budget ownership, and acted as internal champions, solutions are more likely to be successful.

"Every time, we want the owner of the problem to be in the project. They are the experts. This achieves commitment — 'I have committed, this is a great project', and then they will fight for it." (Scania)

This was particularly noticeable in LH Innovation Hub's and Metron's cases where motivated business units were described as decisive for moving beyond experimentation. This finding was further supported by other experts working with VCL, as Hackmann (2025) stated: "pilot success, scale failure" due to missing operational owner. This is governance, not technology."

Additional Quotes can be found in **Appendix N:** Additional Quotes Scaling Enablers.

4.5.2 Implementation Tensions

While we can see the previously named enabling conditions, the data equally provides information on the difficulties of scaling venture clienting. A central tension named by multiple interviewees is the pilot-to-adoption gap, however adoption being the most important phase to create a genuine impact for the organization. Pilots have been described as necessary but not sufficient for long-term integration.

"Teams change, priorities change, the pilot took very long and the momentum is gone — one of the most common implementation failures. The scope is much bigger, the investment much bigger, there are more people involved. The whole situation gets more complex and you need someone dedicated to navigating it." (Service Provider 5)

Especially in product-heavy or regulated contexts, implementation often encounters friction after a technical proof-of-concept (POC) has been achieved. Metron's case illustrates this strongly as long development cycles, quality standards, and dependency concerns make integration substantially harder than piloting. This suggests that the main difficulty often lies within actually implementing external solutions into established systems rather than just finding them.

Another factor playing into the pilot-to-adoption gap is the misalignment of supporting functions such as procurement, legal, and IT.

"IT, procurement, data protection — that's always named at every roundtable. Before we start any project now, we play through all scenarios with IT in advance. The most important thing: never give them the feeling you're a service to be used. You're a partner." (Köster)

Many interviewees have mentioned these as potential bottlenecks within the VCL process and being a cause of speed loss. However, speed is one of the main value propositions of venture clienting, making the handling of this bottleneck essential for long-term success or failure. This challenge is also recognized by other experts working with VCL. Alice Repetti suggested that these challenges could be solved by involving enablers like the legal department from the start (Bär, 2025).

Lastly, there seems to be a friction between flexibility and standardization. As we have seen previously, the VCL process is usually highly standardized and often named as a prerequisite

for scaling and success. At the same time, the interviews show that excessive formalization potentially undermines the adaptability that partly characterizes venture clienting. This was particularly evident in discussions about the use of external service providers and capability building, and creates a tension between dependency and internalization, which will be further discussed in section 4.5.3.

Additional Quotes can be found in **Appendix O:** Additional Quotes Implementation Tensions.

4.5.3 Role of Service Providers

The landscape of service providers and consultants is currently evolving, however there are a few firms that were repeated throughout the interview process. This is partly caused by the fact of predominantly reaching out to companies that were named as clients on these service providers' websites.

Across cases, service providers emerge as a central enabling force in the implementation and scaling of VCL. Hereby, the extent of their support varies from initial setup and process design to full operational execution of venture clienting activities, including startup scouting, screening, and pilot management.

"They are great and they are good to help you get firepower in the beginning. One thing I would challenge though is domain expertise — people in the end have a certain trust if you are somewhat familiar with what they do and come from their company or their realm." (Service Provider 6)

A central contribution of the service providers seems to lie within the initial setup and process implementation. As several interviewees from both sides have indicated, corporates often lack the internal capabilities and experience to do it independently. This is not only because of missing knowledge, but most often because of a lack of resources. Some service providers say themselves that they "make venture clienting projects possible" by supporting both strategic setup and operational execution (SP 3). This highlights their function as intermediaries that help translate this model into a fitting solution for the respective company.

There was a lot of discourse around whether the necessary capabilities for venture clienting can be built and maintained within a firm. While some interviewees argued that they can be built internally or just bought from the outside, not the service but the expert, others emphasized

the importance of external support (HELM). They for examples still fully rely on the service providers' support.

Another approach in Metron's case is that they change service providers frequently according to the respective needs. This suggests that specific capabilities such as startup scouting and execution are not yet fully internalized and remain somewhat interchangeable.

"We regularly reassess our needs. Sometimes we need full process support, sometimes just tools. We also use external partners to challenge and improve our processes even if we already have an established setup — the outside perspective retains value even for mature units." (Metron)

Another interviewee explained how, after having support during the initial process implementation, they have now internalized all capabilities (Lumera). The main reason for this involves the increasing ability of AI to support, especially in Startup Scouting, which suggests a possible reduction in the need for external help in more standardized tasks. In the aviation case, they never hired external help throughout the process (LH Innovation Hub). Though the interviewee highlights lively exchanges with model experts.

"We decided not to use an external service provider because we needed to build the stakeholder relationships and domain knowledge ourselves. In aviation, trust and domain specificity matter enormously — an outsider would struggle to build that from day one." (LH Innovation Hub)

Fully internalizing the process could also bear the risk of losing access to broader startup ecosystems and to startups that have successfully worked in other VCL projects.

This variance in approaches can be linked to how firms manage internal resources and capabilities. Using service providers actively and flexibly substitutes internal full-time equivalents (FTEs), allowing firms to access venture clienting capabilities on demand without committing to permanent internal resources. This reinforces the idea that certain activities, such as startup scouting, are treated as modular and interchangeable rather than core organizational competencies. Altogether, we can notice a tension here between flexibility and capability ownership as service providers enable rapid and structured implementation but may hinder internal learning and long-term capability building. This, however, only finds relevance according to whether it is a firm's goal to eventually build these capabilities internally or if

they prefer the less resource-intensive way, which is supported by multiple service providers themselves:

"It is possible to build VCL internally as well. The question is: is it faster and cheaper to do it with external support? Both ways work. In year 3-4 that's a question you need to ask yourself. A hybrid mode works quite well for most." (Service Provider 1)

Looking at a connection between the maturity of venture clienting units and the use of service providers, no clear pattern can be detected besides early-stage adopters depending heavily on external support (Teknor, HELM, Lumera). Rather than fully internalizing or externalizing capabilities, some firms chose hybrid and task-specific approaches. This suggests that the use of service providers is not necessarily based on the maturity, but rather influenced by other factors such as speed requirements, resource constraints, and the need for external networks and experiences. Altogether, the data suggests that there is no clear trajectory in capability development within this multiple-case study as VCUs of different maturities engage in different stages of hiring service providers or internalizing capabilities. Furthermore, this indicates a continuous balance between dependency and internalization.

Overall, the findings suggest that service providers play a central role not only as enablers but also in standardizing venture clienting practices across organizations. By introducing structured processes and proven methodologies, they support the replicability of venture clienting, especially in the early stages. However, as corporates gain experience, parts of the process potentially become more internalized and supported or even replaced by artificial intelligence. At the same time, the continued selective use of service providers highlights that this standardization does not necessarily make them obsolete but rather shapes their role toward targeted support within hybrid models. This encourages the idea that developing venture clienting capabilities is an ongoing process that is influenced by efficiency, flexibility, and internal capability building.

Additional Quotes can be found in **Appendix P:** Additional Quotes Role of Service Providers.

5 Discussion

This study examined how corporations embed venture clienting into their organizational structures for sourcing external innovation and how VCL influences the balance between exploration and exploitation. This chapter now focuses on interpreting the findings in relation to the theoretical framework established earlier in the literature review. Based on the empirical findings and theoretical frameworks, we created a visual model of venture clienting as an ambidextrous vehicle, which is further explained later in this chapter. Additionally, venture clienting as an emerging corporate innovation model is discussed and considered in connection with the literature. VCL, as an operational form of external exploration, is further explored and paired with previously gained insights from existing research to create a comprehensive understanding. Lastly, this chapter will discuss what kind of impact utilizing venture clienting can have on the balance between exploitation and exploration.

5.1 A Model of Venture Clienting Becoming an Ambidextrous Mechanism

Based on Bruchhage et al's (2024, p. 7) VCL process, existing literature on ambidexterity, including Gibson & Birkinshaw (2004), study findings, and evolved themes above, we developed a model that illustrates how venture clienting becomes a mechanism enabling organizational ambidexterity through six different layers: antecedents, the VCL vehicle, embedding mechanisms, integration dynamics, outcomes, and downstream impacts.

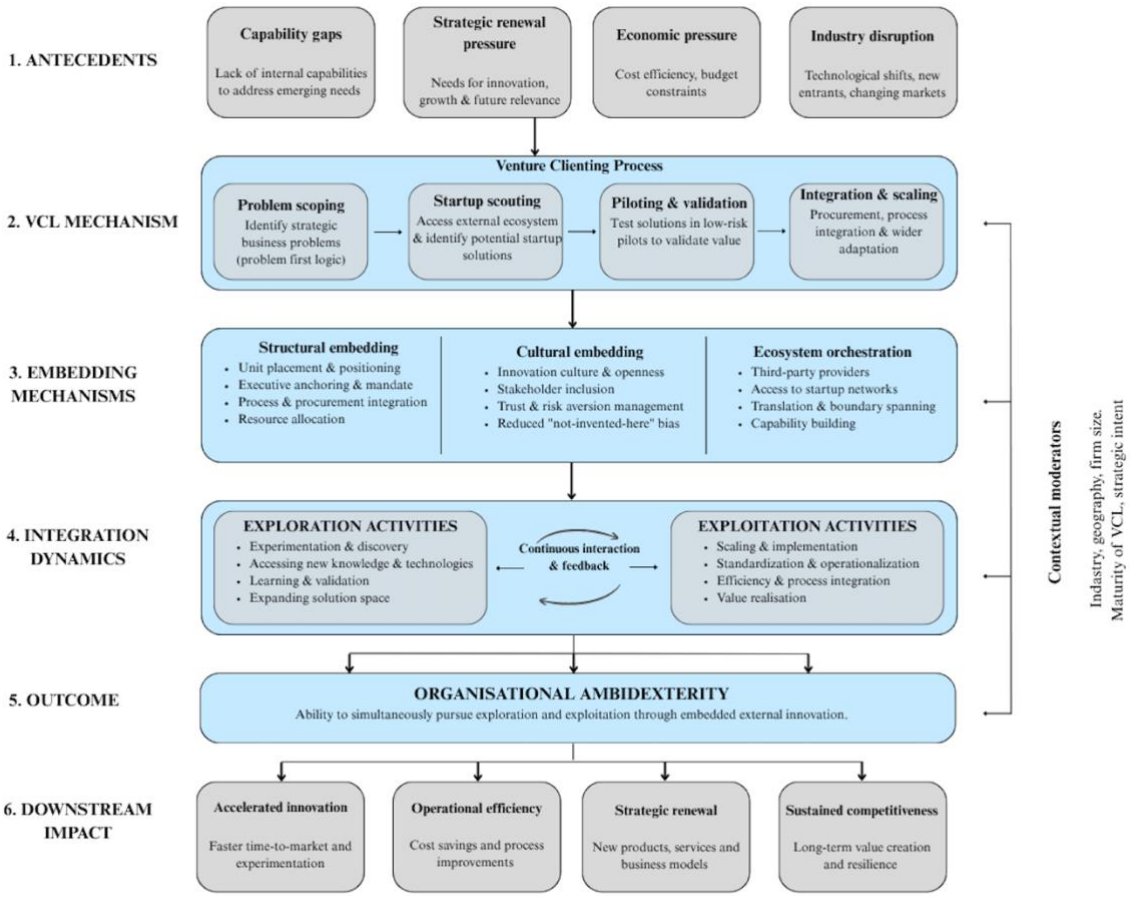


Figure 4: Model of Venture Clienting as an Ambidextrous Mechanism

The first layer of the model shows the conditions that motivate organizations to adopt venture clienting. There were four main antecedents emerging from the data: capability gaps, where the organization's internal competencies are insufficient to meet the needs; strategic renewal pressure, driven by the competition and need for innovation; economic pressure, which pushes organizations towards more capital-efficient activities; and industry disruption, caused by technological shifts, new market entrants, and changing dynamics in the market. These conditions create the organizational urgency to adopt venture clienting to maintain relevance.

These antecedents create the motivation for organizations to engage in the venture clienting process, which consists of four main stages. Firstly, in the problem scoping stage, the strategic needs are translated into clearly defined and commercially framed challenges. In startup scouting, an organization engages with the external startup ecosystem either by itself or through third-party involvement to identify and shortlist suitable solutions. The piloting and validation

phase tests the selected solutions with low risks, with a predetermined timeframe, and KPIs. Lastly, in the integration and scaling phase, the validated solutions move into wider organizational adoption.

The embedding mechanism layer includes the required organizational work to make venture clienting function effectively. The first mechanism is structural embedding, which refers to the strategic choices about where and how the venture client unit is anchored. The second mechanism, cultural embedding, addresses the human-related dimensions, including innovation culture, openness, stakeholder management and inclusion, trust building, and active management of internal resistance. Lastly, ecosystem orchestration includes the role of the third-party service providers in enabling venture clienting by providing access to their startup networks, carrying out cultural translation between the startup and the established company's logic, and assisting in building internal capabilities over time. These three mechanisms are, in most cases, vital for embedding external innovation and preventing the pilot projects from remaining isolated experiments within the company.

The fourth layer of the model introduces the theoretical core: the dynamic interplay of exploration and exploitation activities. Explorative activities include experimentation, discovery, access to new technologies and knowledge, while explorative activities include scaling and process integration. Venture clienting generates ambidexterity by not separating these two activities into different units, but rather by embedding both into a single process, accommodating them simultaneously depending on the problem portfolio.

The embedding mechanisms and integration dynamics together produce organizational ambidexterity, which then refers to the organization's ability to seek exploitation and exploration simultaneously. This outcome then generates four different categories of downstream impact: accelerated innovation, operational efficiency, strategic renewal, and sustained competitiveness. Accelerated innovation refers to more agile experimentation through startup collaboration and faster time to market responses. Operational efficiency, on the other hand, represents the cost savings and process benefits associated with the exploitation-oriented venture clienting projects. Strategic renewal indicates the new products, services, and business models that reposition the organization and increase its competitiveness. Lastly, the sustained competitiveness represents the organization's increased resilience and adaptive capacity, which is achieved through venture clienting.

Contextual moderators run alongside the entire model, acknowledging that the model does not work identically with every organization. These moderators are the industry sector, the size of organization, VCL maturity, and strategic intent. For instance, companies operating in industries under acute disruptions tend to prioritise more exploratory projects. Another major moderator is VCL maturity, as inexperienced companies often concentrate on exploitation-oriented projects and gradually shift towards a balanced mix of both orientations.

5.2 Venture Clienting as an Emerging Corporate Innovation Model

The existing literature on venture clienting defines it as a form of collaborating with startups by integrating their solutions directly into the company's products, processes, or business models (Bruchhage et al., 2024). Additionally, the literature describes it as a non-equity mode of corporate venturing in which corporates act as clients and not investors (Gimmy, 2017). The findings from this study predominantly align with this conceptualization. Across interviews, respondents consistently described VCL as a structured vehicle for accessing external innovation through startup collaboration without high financial investment or commitment. With ownership not being the goal, the focus lies on operational implementation of innovative solutions and measurable business impact. Words that were frequently used to describe venture clienting were "fast", "low risk", and "cost-efficient" compared to other vehicles such as CVC or venture building, aligning with previous literature. This therefore supports the assumption that organizations are currently looking for innovation vehicles that create valuable business impact without involving too many resources due to volatile economic circumstances. Altogether, the findings here support the understanding of VCL as a distinct external innovation tool characterized by non-equity collaboration and operational implementation.

Comparing the process conceptualized by Haarmann et al. (2023) and the process described by the cases, there is a high level of conformity in the general execution of venture clienting. While Haarmann et al. (2023) defined the process with six main steps: Request, Source, Match, Buy, Pilot, and Adopt, the interviewees most of the time highlighted four or five phases, leaving the "Match" phase out. This, however, does not necessarily mean that the researched companies are not matching the theorized process at all. Rather, the findings suggest that the matching of startup solutions is often part of the Sourcing / Scouting phase rather than being a

separate step. Interviewees highlighted the strong interconnectedness of these activities frequently, suggesting that scouting, evaluation, and matching startups happens within one step. Additionally, the phases were sometimes described using different names: for example, the first step, named “request” by Haarmann et al. (2023), was framed differently by some interviewees: Problem identification, Problem discovery, or Problem deep dive.

If the service providers’ perspectives on the process are considered, both in the interviews and on their websites, it becomes visible that usually the interviewed firms follow the approach suggested by their respective service providers. These processes then either consist of four or five phases, similarly, integrating matching into sourcing, and in some cases also leaving out “buy” as a separate phase. This is probably also where the origin of the different naming lies.

These findings suggest that the venture clienting process is already highly conceptualized and standardized in practice. Despite differences in industry, maturity, and company size of the cases, the interviewed experts described similar process structures and operational logics, mostly aligning with existing literature. Especially organizations working with external service providers seem to adopt a relatively formalized venture clienting approach, including governance structures and repeatable processes.

Altogether, this supports the argument that venture clienting is moving from ad hoc startup collaboration toward an institutionalized organizational capability for bringing in external innovation systematically. Simultaneously, the data suggests that certain process phases, including matching and buying, are often operationally integrated into the previous or following phases. This might indicate that while the process is often highly structured, organizations still adapt the individual phases depending on their organizational context, VCL maturity, and their experience.

5.3 VCL as an Operational Form of External Exploration

The findings suggest that venture clienting occupies a special position within the broader corporate venturing landscape. As shown in Figure 1, most of the selected corporate venture tools are located in a capital-intensive position with a long-term time horizon. VCL, in contrast, was repeatedly highlighted as fast impact with low resource needs. While there was the previous assumption that venture clienting might be replacing, for example, CVC or venture

building, the interviewees consistently described VCL as complementary to other forms of external innovation.

This aligns with Haarmann et al.'s (2023) conceptualization of corporate venturing as a portfolio of multiple mechanisms and Keil's (2004) original reasoning that they follow different governance logics and strategic objectives. While CVC is primarily associated with financial involvement, long-term strategic positioning, and access to emerging technologies through equity ownership, VCL focuses on the operational adoption and testing of startup solutions without involving equity and creating a faster impact. In this sense, venture clienting represents a form of exploration through use rather than ownership. Rather than replacing equity-based approaches such as CVC, it complements them by enabling firms to operationalize external exploration through experimentation and direct implementation of startup solutions.

Furthermore, the findings indicate that VCL increasingly gains importance right now in uncertain economic times because of its relatively low-risk and operational nature. Within the interviews, there was often a juxtaposition of venture clienting with venture building, both relatively new vehicles. Contrasting these two showed that venture building is resource-intensive, slower in generating outcomes, and difficult to justify under tighter innovation budgets, leading to a loss of momentum; however, it still shows many success cases, also within the case sample (LH Innovation Hub). This observation suits a McKinsey report from 2025, which argues that corporations increasingly seek external innovation vehicles that are faster, more flexible, and involve lower upfront commitments (Banholzer et al., 2025).

Consequently, the findings position VCL as a form of external exploration that prioritizes operational value creation over speculative financial return. Instead of focusing primarily on future exit potential or ownership stakes, firms engage with startups to solve concrete business problems, improve processes, and accelerate implementation of new technologies. While there is a multitude of advantages to venture clienting in comparison to CVC, VCL's exploration might come with lower variance and might narrow in scope due to a variance of startup requirements.

When looking at the complementary characteristic of venture clienting, the interviews suggested that the function of VCL does not necessarily compete with other corporate venturing vehicles but may instead create synergies with them. Many interviewees described

venture clienting as a potential entry point or operational complement to activities such as CVC. These synergies can emerge both ways: On one hand, existing CVC activities can offer access to already approved startups. This, however, bears the risk of using startups that would not necessarily have been chosen in an unbiased sourcing process. On the other hand, venture clienting can be a form of due diligence through use, allowing firms to make investment decisions based on their actually experienced knowledge. This phenomenon, sometimes called "test-before-invest" by the interviewees, could create possible new synergies emerging within the field of corporate venturing that could even enhance their future leverage. This interplay could be interpreted as a shift towards more integrated and iterative corporate venturing approaches, where different tools create synergies with each other to balance immediate impact with future-oriented innovation. While Heiduk et al. (2025) have described some of these findings, this study contributes to a further conceptualization of venture clienting as part of the corporate venture landscape and the synergies between venture clienting and corporate venture capital.

5.4 VCL as a Balancing Tool Between Exploration and Exploitation

To answer our research question related to ambidexterity, the following question is what implications VCL has on the balance between exploration and exploitation within the organizations, and what it means in relation to ambidexterity theory. Our empirical findings offer the following answer: VCL does not merely introduce exploration to an exploitative organization, nor does it increase exploration at the cost of exploitation. Rather, VCL can integrate both orientations into the same team and process, a configuration that aligns with contextual ambidexterity.

In structural ambidexterity, exploration and exploitation are in separate dedicated organizational units, while in contextual ambidexterity, both orientations are simultaneously sought within the same unit (Birkinshaw and Gibson 2004; Kumkale, 2022). While CVC can be seen as a textbook example of structural ambidexterity as it maintains exploratory distance from the core business of the organization, having separate teams, investment logic and fund, VCL operates in a completely different manner. VCUs are often located inside the organization, working closely with different business units to maintain a continuous inflow of

business problems. Therefore, considering different forms of ambidexterity, VCL can be seen as an example of contextual ambidexterity.

However, empirical findings revealed a consistent pattern: a systematic pull towards exploitation-natured projects in the early-stage VCL portfolio. In nearly all corporate cases in this research, process improvement topics, such as AI productivity tools and document automation, were more prevalent. Service provider interviewee described a typical 80/20 split between process and product projects in the early phase, and Lumera's representative described them using VCL almost entirely for exploitation projects. These findings could be seen as a limitation of VCL's ambidextrous claim. However, we argue that it is better to look at it through Simsek's (2009, p 603) perspective, which proposes that organizational ambidexterity is not necessarily about the equal and simultaneous pursuit of both sides, but rather about a dynamic balance of the organization's current priorities and demands. The exploitation-heavy early portfolio is likely a rational response to two aspects: process innovations produce measurable business impact faster, which enables the justification of the VCU's existence, and secondly, projects of this nature are perceived as safer and less threatening for internal capabilities. Therefore, instead of considering this as a model failure, such a starting point reflects the logic of first building credibility before shifting to more complex, uncertain, and exploratory projects.

This leads us to what we consider to be one of the most novel theoretical contributions emerging from our findings: the maturity effect. The empirical data revealed a consistent pattern: as venture client units gained organizational credibility, stakeholder trust, and internal track record, they started shifting more towards exploratory projects. Scania can be seen representing one of the most mature venture client cases in our sample, now operating with a roughly equal process-product balance and describing its orientation as exploratory in intent. Service providers further confirmed this trajectory to be a common pattern across the VCU engagements they had observed. Current ambidexterity theory considers the exploitation-exploration balance as a static organizational characteristic, which is determined by structure, leadership orientation, or context. However, the maturity effect suggests a different perspective: VCL contributes to ambidexterity not in a static, but in a developmental manner, venture client unit can become progressively more ambidextrous as it matures. However, we suggest that this maturing effect is possible only if the company offers products, as companies without product offerings can do exploration only to a limited extent. Their exploration can be

visible through business model exploration; however, we cannot be sure it bears the same effect.

Another considerable dimension of VCL's ambidexterity is its institutional resilience. A service provider interviewee explains that during periods of cost pressure and budget reallocation, other vehicles like CVC are more vulnerable as when efficiency is prioritized, exploration-oriented programs get eliminated. At the same time, when growth is emphasized, exploitation-oriented programs are less prioritized. Therefore, VCL's ability to contribute to both orientations makes it more resilient compared to vehicles serving only one orientation. Another service provider supported the finding by stating that she is not aware of any venture client unit that would have been permanently closed. By comparison, she mentioned witnessing many CVC units being shut down. Considering this from an ambidexterity theory's perspective, VCL can be seen as a vehicle that is able to justify itself in both exploitation and exploration sides and therefore, enabling the long-term ambidextrous performance.

6. Conclusions

To conclude this research, this chapter goes into detail on the theoretical, practical, and managerial implications. Following the implications, the limitations of the research are acknowledged and discussed. Furthermore, we make suggestions for future research that arise from the limitations of this study.

6.1 Theoretical Implications

As noted in the literature review, venture clienting has remained very limitedly researched. Previous literature has concentrated on the process of venture clienting and has treated VCL mainly as a complementary operational vehicle to CVC (Haarmann et al., 2023; Keil, 2004; Gimmy et al., 2017). However, our research focus was on how organizations embed venture clienting to enable the use of externally sourced innovation within the organization and what implications the model has on organizational ambidexterity. Still, parts of our findings challenge the previous literature, especially related to the relationship between VCL and CVC. The findings of our study suggest that VCL is a vehicle with a largely different governance logic for accessing external innovation. CVC explores external innovation through ownership, while VCL explores by operational validation and use of the innovation. CVC maintains structural distance from the core business of the organization, while VCL seeks to embed exploration within operational processes and products directly. Therefore, we argue that VCL deserves its own theoretical category, one that is defined by both exploitation-exploration and operational proximity.

Another theoretical implication from our research is a new understanding of venture clienting as a part of ambidexterity. Organizational ambidexterity has largely been theorized as an ability to balance exploitation and exploration simultaneously. Simsek (2009) further suggests that ambidexterity is in fact not about simultaneously equally pursuing both sides, but rather about dynamic balance based on current priorities. However, what our findings suggest is that VCL's level of ambidexterity evolves over time. The empirical data revealed a consistent pattern: units initially have process exploitation-dominated portfolios, and over time progressively move towards more explorative projects. This can be seen as an important theoretical implication because if VCL's ambidexterity is not static, then the standard approach of measuring the

organizational ambidexterity at a single point in time is not suitable, perhaps even misleading. A VCU observed in its first year is likely to appear very different than when observed five years later again. However, it is important to note that such a maturing effect is not possible in companies with no product production; these companies are able to utilize VCL for process exploitation purposes.

Based on the empirical data, we created a conceptual model of venture clienting, which was presented in the findings section. The model suggests six interconnected layers: antecedent conditions, which include capability gaps, strategic renewal, and economic pressure, and industry disruption, which drives companies towards VCL. The second layer introduces the VCL process with its four main stages, followed by the third layer, which is the embedding mechanism. Structural, cultural, and ecosystem are the aspects determining the success of the VCL. The fourth layer then introduces the two orientations which, when properly balanced leads to the fifth layer: organizational ambidexterity. Lastly, the sixth layer shows the downstream impacts of the process: accelerated innovation, operational efficiency, strategic renewal, and sustained competitiveness. Along the side, the models also acknowledge the contextual moderators, industry, geography, firm size, VCU maturity, and strategic intent, which impact the nature and strength of the relationships between different layers. The main theoretical contribution of the model lies in the "embedding mechanisms" layer, which has not been discussed in previous theories or literature. The above-mentioned embedding mechanisms shape what kind of ambidexterity will be achieved by determining the proximity of the VCU to business problems and organizational authority, but also whether the pilot outputs are absorbed in the organization or not.

The recognition of the 2024 Gartner Hype Cycle and venture clienting has a specific theoretical implication: it signals the shift of VCL, a practice that has existed informally for a long time, becoming an established organizational vehicle. As noted in the findings, several interviewees recognized that established companies have always been clients of startups; however, the new aspect is the scalable process and governance structure around it. This is relevant as it signals that the theoretical development of VCL is not starting from scratch but rather is an already existing practice that has outgrown its informal origin. There is also a theoretical caution: the overuse of the venture clienting label. Here, organizations announce their VCL programs but without fully adopting its underlying structures, increasing the risk of conflating the term and model, and therefore, making it harder to theorize the topic. Lastly, the shift from piloting to

adoption was described as the next maturation frontier by the interviewees, signaling organizational embedding to be a theoretically underdeveloped dimension of venture clienting, which our study begins to address through the "embedding mechanisms" layer in the conceptual model.

6.2 Practical & Managerial Implications

In addition to the contributions of this study to academic literature, our findings provide practical implications.

For effective VCL, one might want to start with the problem, not the process. The empirical data described starting VCL without a specific problem as a consistent failure mode. VCL requires a concrete and specific business challenge with well-defined success criteria and a motivated internal problem owner with sufficient authority. When organizations focus on designing the VCL process over identifying the problem portfolio, it increases the likelihood of producing learning without actually adopting it. Therefore, managers might want to concentrate first on building the problem pipeline and invest in a well-structured problem identification process before focusing on building the unit.

Another aspect to take into consideration is where to anchor the venture client unit. Where the VCU sits in the organization, who it reports to, its relation to internal R&D, IT, and procurement are all structural positioning questions, which affect the unit's ability to function fast and effectively. These strategic coaches have a major impact on the future of the unit, what kinds of problems the unit has access to, what sort of solutions the unit can pilot, and whether those pilots can be scaled in the future or not. For example, units that are anchored in IT or operations are likely to gravitate more towards process improvements, and units reporting to the senior executive level are able to navigate better with procurement, legal, and IT gatekeepers because of the organizational authority. Therefore, managers might want to choose the anchoring of the VCU deliberately, based on the strategic goals and desired exploitation-exploration balance.

Building organizational credibility is necessary before pursuing exploratory projects. The referred maturity effect has direct managerial implications: an exploitation-heavy early phase is the path to exploratory VCL projects. Attempting to pursue product-based exploratory projects before building a track record of success cases increases the possibility of internal

resistance. “Quick wins” that are visible, measurable, and tied to business unit priorities are vital in the early phases of VCL. For these reasons, managers are suggested to organize their problem portfolio by beginning with certain, process-based cases that generate trust and credibility, but also demonstrate the value of the VCU. Over time, the unit can seek to pursue more ambitious, complex, exploratory cases once the foundation is built.

Furthermore, pilots are for adoption purposes. The adaptation gap, meaning the failure of scaling the successful pilots, is one of the most crucial failure points identified from the data. If scoped too broadly or left without a pre-determined budget owner, a pilot is not likely to transition to full adaptation regardless of the success of the pilot. For this reason, managers might consider the adoption planning as one major component of pilot design, not just a downstream decision. Before beginning the pilot, having the following aspects cleared can help: Who is the budget owner, the procurement pathway, required IT integration, and which organizational stakeholder will own the solution after a successful pilot.

Lastly, this study supports the idea of exploiting synergies between venture clienting and corporate venture capital. As previously described, these synergies can work both directions: VCL as a first step to CVC, or CVC offering access to already examined startups. In practice, this means for managers that a close relationship between these two functions might enhance each corporate venturing vehicle’s performance. By maintaining that relationship firms can move toward a more integrated venturing approach where operational validation and financial investment can reinforce each other and contribute to strategic impact of external innovation, as well as potentially further contributing to the organization’s balance between exploration and exploitation.

6.3 Limitations of the Study

While aiming for the highest quality and robustness possible, there have been some limitations to this study. First, the chosen study design of a qualitative multi-case study often comes with the risk of subjective interpretation and bias. Since the study relies heavily on expert interviews supported by secondary data, mostly from additional experts sharing their knowledge on LinkedIn, the findings are shaped by their specific perceptions and experiences. In addition to that, the researcher’s interpretation of the data factors in, although efforts were made to ensure consistency and neutrality through an interview guide and cross-case analysis.

Secondly, the interview sample consists of six service providers who all work for firms that are selling the venture clienting model as their main service. Therefore, these interviewees generally support or promote venture clienting and tend to strongly emphasize its success and strategic value, which became clear when some struggled to elaborate on potential downsides or critical limitations. Overall, this might have led to a generally positive bias, which was attempted to be mitigated by the authors. The use of these service providers also led to the selection process for the case companies. With that, there might exist a bias concerning the work of their respective service providers, which could be perceived as very positive.

Third, aligning with the previous limitation, is the usage of case companies from only Germany, Sweden, and Finland. This limits the generalizability of results across the globe and rather facilitates comparability in Western and Northern Europe. Also, most of the cases companies are multinationals. Therefore, they do not represent SMEs and other forms of firms in how they use venture clienting.

Further, it is arguable how comparable the findings of the cases are due to their different industries, structures, VCL maturities, strategic objectives, and even ownerships. While some case firms already have fully established venture clienting units, others have just started or use a fully decentralized approach. Then, the industries vary from banking to aviation to construction, and ownership models differ from family-owned to state-owned to belonging to a group like Lufthansa. While these differences inherently raise this question of generalizability, they did not necessarily seem to be a limiting factor, but rather showed how similarly the model is used across the cases. There have been some outliers, specifically the banking case, to an extent that a more decentralized approach was used and that the banking industry seems to face challenges of scepticism and security more than others.

Lastly, the findings of this study are purely qualitative as described previously. Therefore, it was limited in quantifying the actual impact of venture clienting. While this impact and low-risk characteristics were named repeatedly, the qualitative nature of the paper does not allow for measuring financial performance, comparing success to other corporate venture vehicles, efficiency gains ,or long-term organizational impact.

6.4 Future Research

Future research could build on this study by conducting quantitative research to validate and generalize the findings above across a larger sample of firms. Due to the qualitative nature of this study, future studies could enhance the findings by examining the relationships between venture clienting and its outcomes, such as performance, adoption success, and efficiency gains. This way, it could be numerically proven whether the mechanisms identified in this study are consistent across organizations and industries, and how well venture clienting actually performs.

Additionally, future research could broaden the scope from well-established and multinational firms towards medium-sized firms or smaller organizations seeking innovation with limited resources. Comparative studies across different firm sizes and organizational structures could provide deeper insights into how the execution of venture clienting varies depending on organizational context.

Lastly, additional insight could be gained by involving the perspective of the third actor in venture clienting: that of the startups. While they were not relevant in answering this paper's research questions, they could contribute another angle to future research as they might have different experiences on partnership dynamics including potential power relations, dependencies or trade-offs.

7. Outlook: Is Venture Clienting just a Hype?

To finish this thesis, we want to give an outlook on venture clienting and discuss the question: Is venture clienting just a hype, and how will it evolve?

A common topic across the interviews was the question of whether venture clienting represents a temporary trend or a sustainable shift in corporate innovation practices. Several interviewees acknowledged the growing visibility of the concept, especially referring to a growing professional network characterized by industry exchanges and roundtables (LH Innovation Hub, Teknor). Mainly coming from the service providers, but also some case experts, the Gartner Hype Cycle was mentioned (SP 2 & SP 3). The Gartner Hype Cycle describes the progression of emerging technologies and innovation practices throughout five different phases, which can be seen below (Gimmy, 2025). It is commonly used to illustrate how new concepts move from early hype toward sustainable and productive implementation.

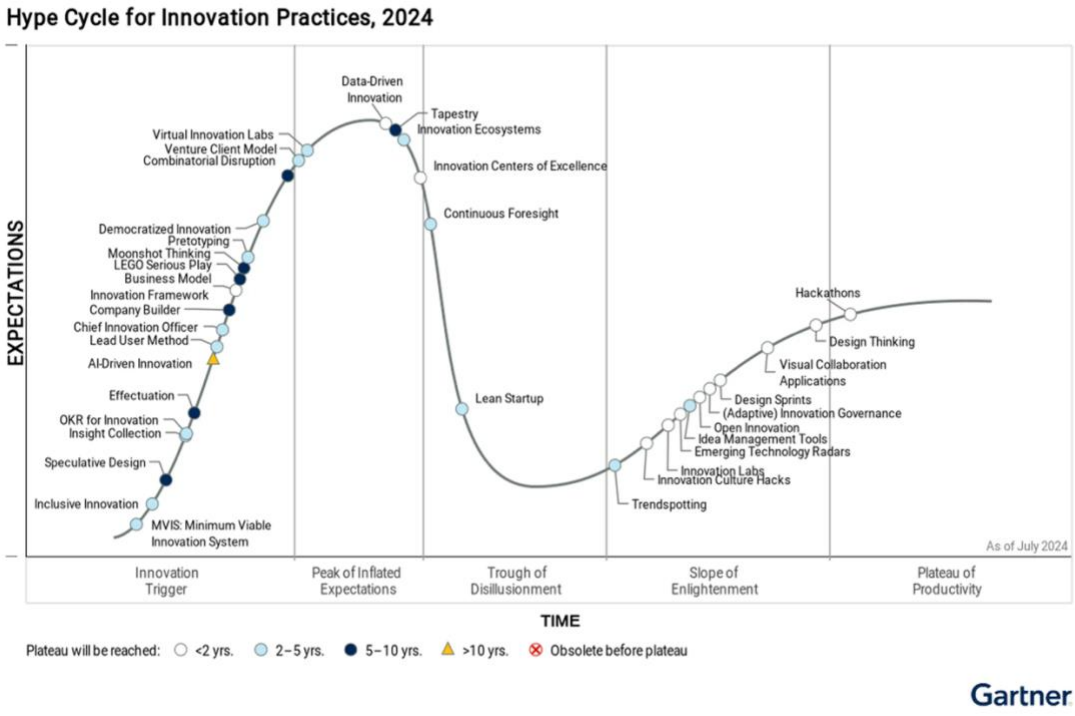


Figure 5: Gartner Hype Cycle 2024 (Gartner, 2024)

The inclusion of VCL in the Gartner Hype Cycle in 2024 aligns with the broader observation that the model is going through a phase of strong enthusiasm at this point in time, with sometimes an inflationary use of the wording ‘venture clienting’ itself. Venture Clienting

“founder” Gregor Gimmy has described the featuring of VCL in the Hype Cycle as proof of visibility and recognition, attracting more future adopters of the model and as validation for its value and success within corporations (Gimmy, 2025). At the same time, he highlights that being close to reaching the top of stage 2 comes with the challenge of transitioning successfully to a practical application with the final goal of reaching stage 5: the Plateau of Productivity.

The findings reveal, however, that while the terminology and formalization of the VCL model have gained traction in the last ten years, several interviewees emphasized that the practice of being an early client of a startup is not new. SP3 argued in the interview that corporates have always been buying from startups, just without a designated process and governance structure. Therefore, the current attention can be interpreted as less the emergence of a completely new approach but rather the scalable formalization of an already established practice.

At the same time, there are patterns and indicators named by the interviewees that fulfil this trend or hype dynamics. It was pointed out that corporates publicly announce their use of the venture client model while in reality they are not fully adopting its underlying processes and structures (Alpha Corp, Karls). This suggests that the diffusion around the word has possibly caused an inconsistent use and understanding of the venture clienting model.

Despite these hype-like dynamics and the intake of venture clienting into the Gartner Hype Cycle, the interviews suggest the increasing maturation of the model. Most of the interviews have shown that the case organizations are adopting scalable and integrated structures surrounding VCL, including a dedicated unit, engagement in networks, and cross-functional collaboration mechanisms. Especially in times of economic uncertainty and budget pressure, venture clienting was repeatedly described as a comparatively low-risk and fast-impact-oriented vehicle to other corporate venture vehicles, making it outlast, for example, venture building and venture capital (SP 5). SP 5 described venture clienting as attractive because it is “cheaper”, requires “no capital investment”, and creates more direct business impact. LH Innovation Hub’s expert similarly argued that venture clienting is “the most risk-free yet with very high impact or potential impact way to innovate” (LH Innovation Hub).

The outlook for venture clienting was therefore described by most interviewees as positive despite currently being on top of a hype. Several respondents indicated that the first hype wave may already be over, but that the model itself, if well-embedded and not just used for its name, is likely to remain as an established vehicle for accessing and embedding external innovation.

Particularly, the growing pressure on corporates to generate measurable innovation impact while simultaneously reducing costs appears to strengthen the attractiveness of VCL compared to more investment- or resource-intensive venturing vehicles. These findings are further supported by other practitioners of venture clienting. Venture clienting specialist Sebastian Schäfer describes the current state as “one of the hottest topics” (Moore, 2026). Still, the common opinion among professionals in the field suggests that venture clienting will grow in popularity in the future.

Finally, another recurring theme involving the outlook for venture clienting is the shift from conducting successful pilots to a higher adoption rate of the startup solutions. Interviewees from the cases repeatedly highlighted that they do not currently struggle with identifying and piloting startup solutions but successfully adopting and integrating them internally due to different reasons. This aligns with Gregor Gimmy’s previous description of moving the venture client toward the stage 5 Plateau of Productivity to fully exploit the impact potential venture clienting offers by implementing and scaling startup solutions to a greater extent (Grimmy, 2024). This aligns with the responses from multiple service providers who argued that their role might shift soon from startup scouting and piloting toward a heavier focus on providing support during long-term implementation and the adoption phase (SP 2). This suggests that the future development and maturation of venture clienting may increasingly depend on the ability of corporates to operationally embed externally sourced innovations into existing organizational structures and processes by overcoming challenges such as long development cycles or frictions with other business functions such as IT.

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Appendix

Appendix A: Interview Guide Corporates

Interview Guide – Corporates

Background & Role

1. Could you briefly describe your role and your involvement with Venture Clienting activities in the company?
2. When and why did your company start engaging in Venture Clienting and why?

Strategic Purpose of Venture Clienting

3. Where is Venture Clienting positioned in the organization?
4. What are the main objectives your company pursues through Venture Clienting?
5. How does Venture Clienting complement or differ from other innovation activities in your organization (e.g., internal R&D, partnerships, Corporate Venture Capital)?
6. What role does CVC play in your organization?
7. Do you see Venture Clienting as an addition or substituion for CVC, and why?

Venture Clienting Process

8. Could you walk us through the typical process from identifying a problem to implementing a solution in the organization?
9. What criteria determine whether a startup solution moves from a pilot to broader implementation?

Embedding External Innovation

10. What internal mechanisms or structures help ensure that successful pilots are adopted by the business units? What are main challenges?
11. Can you describe a case where a startup solution was successfully integrated into core operations?

Organizational Dynamics

12. What kinds of resistances or barriers do you encounter internally?
13. How do you encourage internal teams to adopt solutions developed by startups?

Exploration vs. Exploitation (Ambidexterity)

14. Do you see collaborations with startups primarily as a way to explore new technologies and opportunities, or to exploit existing capabilities? Explain
15. How do you ensure that collaborations with startups don't disrupt existing operational processes?

Reflection

16. How do you determine success in Venture Clienting?
17. What are the most important success factors for Venture Clienting?
18. What is the role of third party service providers in establishing Venture Clienting?
19. If another firm wanted to implement Venture Clienting, what advice would you give them?

Appendix B: Interview Guide Service Providers

Interview Guide – Venture Clienting Service Providers

Beginning

- Introduction of Interviewers and topic
- Introduction of Interviewee and experience with Venture Clienting

Understanding Venture Clienting as a Model

1. What it your definition of Venture Clienting and how would you describe the process?
2. How does it differ from CVC?
3. In your experience, what organizational problems does Venture Clienting primarily solve and what is the strategic goal?
4. What are the reasons why firms are now adapting Venture Clienting?
5. Do you think it is a substitution or addition for CVC or internal R&D?

Organizational Embedding

6. What organizational prerequisites are necessary for Venture Clienting to work long term?
7. What role does culture play in the implementation of Venture Clienting?
8. Where should it be anchored (innovation unit, procurement, business unit)?
9. How do core business units and venture client teams interact and possibly navigate tensions?
10. What happens when startup solutions challenge existing capabilities or power structures?
11. How do firms ensure that solutions don't remain isolated pilots?

Exploration–Exploitation Dynamics

12. In what way does Venture Clienting support exploration, exploitation, or both?
13. Ambidexterity focuses on balancing those two: How can VCL help doing that?
14. How does Venture Clienting interact with internal R&D?

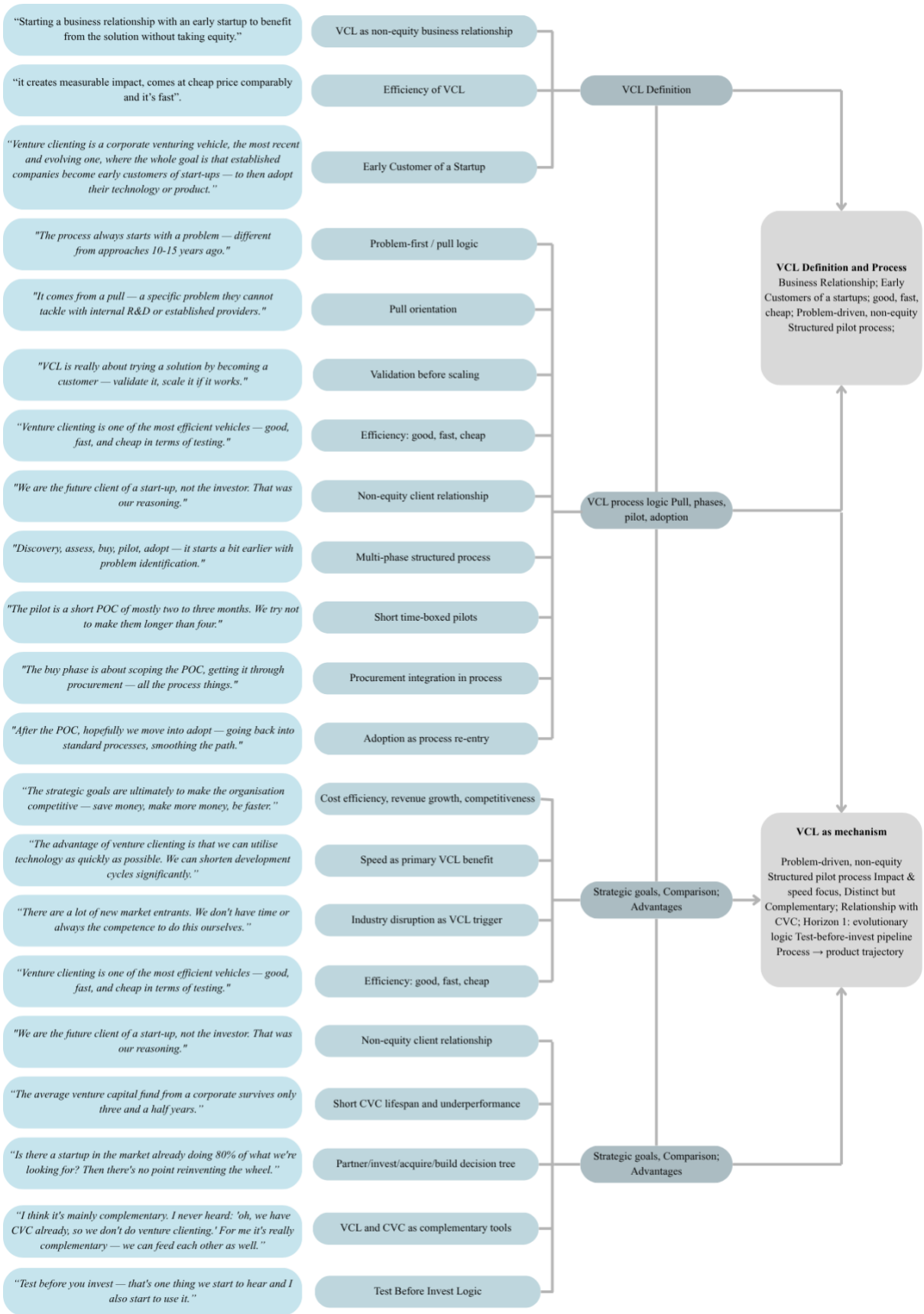
Opportunities & Challenges

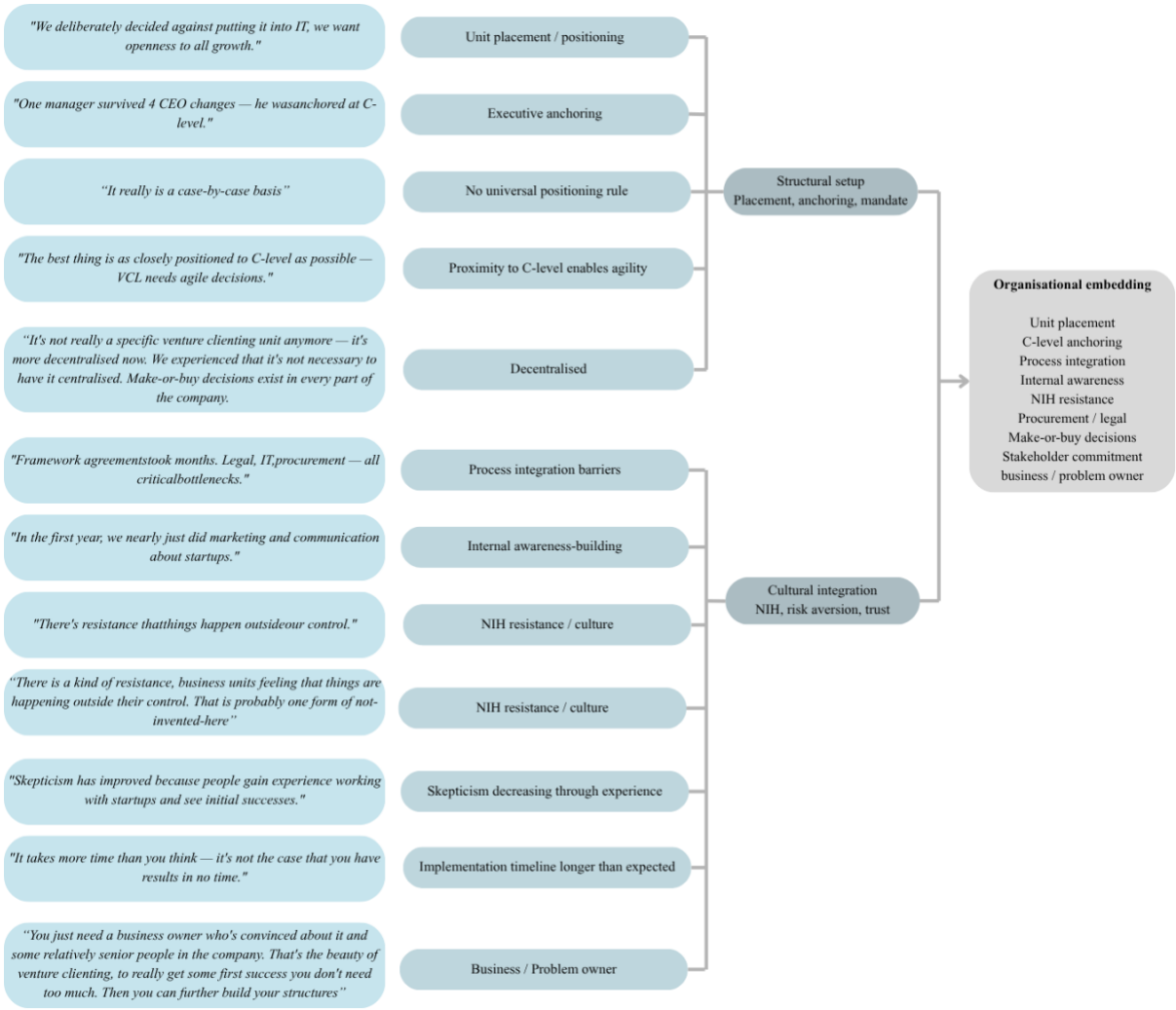
15. How can Venture Clienting reduce risk compared to CVC?
16. What challenges might Venture Clienting face?

Institutionalization & Scaling

17. How does Venture Clienting evolve over time within firms?
18. What distinguishes firms that do it successfully?
19. What kind of structures, industries or general factors do you see that support the implementation of Venture Clienting in firms?
20. What role do service providers like you play?

Appendix C: Coding Map




"We deliberately decided against putting it into IT, we want openness to all growth."
Unit placement / positioning
"One manager survived 4 CEO changes — he wasanchored at C-level."
Executive anchoring
"It really is a case-by-case basis"
No universal positioning rule
"The best thing is as closely positioned to C-level as possible — VCL needs agile decisions."
Proximity to C-level enables agility
"It's not really a specific venture clienting unit anymore — it's more decentralised now. We experienced that it's not necessary to have it centralised. Make-or-buy decisions exist in every part of the company."
Decentralised
Structural setup
Placement, anchoring, mandate
"Framework agreementstook months. Legal, IT,procurement — all criticalbottlenecks."
Process integration barriers
"In the first year, we nearly just did marketing and communication about startups."
Internal awareness-building
"There's resistance thatthings happen outsideour control."
NIH resistance / culture
"There is a kind of resistance, business units feeling that things are happening outside their control. That is probably one form of not-invented-here"
NIH resistance / culture
"Skepticism has improved because people gain experience working with startups and see initial successes."
Skepticism decreasing through experience
"It takes more time than you think — it's not the case that you have results in no time."
Implementation timeline longer than expected
"You just need a business owner who's convinced about it and some relatively senior people in the company. That's the beauty of venture clienting, to really get some first success you don't need too much. Then you can further build your structures"
Business / Problem owner
Cultural integration
NIH, risk aversion, trust
Organisational embedding
Unit placement
C-level anchoring
Process integration
Internal awareness
NIH resistance
Procurement / legal
Make-or-buy decisions
Stakeholder commitment
business / problem owner


"in itself almost an ambidextrous innovation tool"
"80% process topics at start — they succeed quicker, build narrative."
"It's absolutely about exploring. So we want to see, try out new technology"
"There's conflict between startup speed and what we can adapt to."
"Very few VCLs have stopped — many CVCs have been wound down."
"It starts with exploration more — and of course it can evolve into more of an exploit role."
"It's more about exploiting existing potentials, because as a bank we are, in a technological view, very behind in many dimensions"
"The big added value is the network in the startup ecosystem that we don't have — business teams' time used efficiently."
"Combient: corporates cooperate for peer-to-peer learning — quite a different model than project-based SPs."
"In year 3 or 4, the question is: do we need external support? A hybrid mode works well."
"They have the networkwe don't have. Businessteams' time is usedefficiently."
"Someone needs to dothe translation betweenstartups and corporates."
"Mittelstand firms wantto train internal peopleand stop needing them."
"Combient: corporatescooperate for peer-to-peer learning."
"It all starts with us having a business owner who has a real problem."
"You should have a strong mandate from top management, it's still a long-term game"
"It's really hard to have a project with a startup if the startup is substituting some internal work. Nobody would like that"
"At the end of the day you need to generate impact. It needs to be a business relevant problem, cost savings or additional revenue."
"We did in the first year nearly justmarketing and communication"
"Most important are stakeholder commitment, the hardest to get."
"Startups: commercially mature solutions only —not R&D funding."
Ambidextrous tool
Process vs. product split
Exploration leaning
Exploration–exploitation tension
CVC complementarity / shift
VCL as exploration-first, then exploitation
Exploitation leaning
SP as ecosystem access & scouting
Alliance / consortium SP model
SP relationship evolves over VCL maturity
Ecosystem access & network
Cultural translation role
Build vs. buy capability
Alliance / consortium model
Problem ownership
Management backing
Complementary tool for internal R&D
Generate results
Internal communication
Stakeholder inclusion
Stakeholder inclusion
Exploration &exploitation dynamics
Ambidextrous mechanism
Third-party provider role
Network, translation, capability
Service providervalue proposition
Capability internalisation
Organisational enablers
Startup collaboration quality
Exploration–exploitation dynamics
Ambidextrous tool
explorationProcess = exploitationProduct = explorationRapid learning cyclesSpeed advantage
E&E tensions
CVC complementarity
Test-before-invest
Third-party provider role
Ecosystem network, Process methodology, Cultural translation, Build vs. buy tension, Alliance model, Software-only option, Long-term partnership
Success factors & failure modes
Problem ownership, C-level backing, Stakeholder inclusion, Right startup maturity, Adoption commitment, Impact generation, People as key factor

Appendix D: Additional Quotes Definition of Venture Clienting and its Process

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Service Provider 4	Venture clienting is like starting a business relationship with an early start-up to benefit from the solution without taking equity in the start-up. It's a purely business relationship which benefits both sides.
Service Provider 2	Venture clienting is a corporate venturing vehicle, the most recent and evolving one, where the whole goal is that established companies become early customers of start-ups — to then adopt their technology or product.
Service Provider 3	The process works as follows: corporates start with a problem statement — it comes from a pull, not a push — a specific problem they cannot tackle with internal R&D or established providers. We identify solutions and test them in a low-effort pilot with the goal of a long-term buyer-supply relationship.
Service Provider 5	Venture clienting is really about trying a solution by becoming a customer or a proof of concept — you want to validate the solution if it works and scale it if it does.
Service Provider 1	The process always starts — and this is the most important part — with a problem. It's different from approaches 10–15 years ago that started with a cool idea they wanted to push into an organization.
Service Provider 6	Venture clienting, you could maybe describe it as somewhat of a very innovative procurement process — contracting with other entities in a lean, efficient way.
Köster GmbH	The process starts with strategic fields and pain points, then goes into scouting — a long list, short list, follow-ups — then a POC in a protected environment with real data, before moving to piloting and implementation. The most important foundation is first building the internal network to get real pain points.
Karls Oy*	We first build awareness, then prioritize, then organize a problem deep-dive session of 60 minutes, then scouting, then a graded list of 5–10 startups, then bilateral discussions, then a demo, then a proof of concept.
LH Innovation Hub	We start with problem discovery — asking about use case requirements, quantitative impact hypothesis, who's involved, what's the budget. Then scouting with a long list turning into a short list. Then solution insourcing with a standardized POC contract. Then piloting. Then ideally adoption.
Helm AG	We first start with a problem deep dive. Then the SP goes into scouting. The problem owner sees four startups in a pitch. We discuss pricing and pilot conditions, run the pilot based on KPIs, and then evaluate for full adoption.
Metron AG*	It starts with problem identification or a request from a business unit. Then scouting. Then matching — from longlist to shortlist. Then demo or pitch sessions with one to three startups. Then a pilot project. Then evaluation. Then the integration phase — which is the one we reach least often.
Teknor SE*	In the past, someone visiting an event, chatting with a startup and then maybe visiting them — that was not a full picture. Venture clienting really helps us have a good overview of the ecosystem and is an unbiased open search.
Lumera*	We identify a use case that cannot be solved by current suppliers. Then we scout the startup market, evaluate, and guide the business department through the pilot process and integration if we are happy with the pilot.
Alpha Corp AB*	We work with startups when we are missing something in our product portfolio or technology. We do pilots and try to get customer feedback before making a decision — it can go from partnership, to buying IP, to acquiring the whole company.
Sovian AG*	We more work with the pull model than the push model. Problems usually come to us. Then we go into the discovery phase, deep dive with the problem owner, make a long list and a short list, decide on the

Case / Service Provider	Quote
	company we pilot, and if successful move into adoption preparation — checking cyber, IT, procurement, legal — before a longer-term agreement.

Appendix E: Additional Quotes Structural Positioning

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Service Provider 4	It's good to have a more independent part in the organization — a visible team. It should be deeply networked in the company — better to have people from the inside. Procurement, strategy, legal, and IT for integration should all be part of this initiative.
Service Provider 2	The only no-go is outside entity. We need to be in the core business. If you have VCL in a different unit outside your core corporate, you're too far away — you're just always the ones doing fun stuff that's not getting anywhere.
Service Provider 3	The best thing could be as closely positioned to the C-level as possible because VCL needs agile decisions. The further down to the bottom it gets, the visibility decreases, the power decreases.
Service Provider 5	It really is a case-by-case basis. It helps if it's not too far from the executive — either the CTO or the chief strategy officer. There's no one-size-fits-all answer. It really depends on the company.
Service Provider 1	It needs to be in the org chart — that's one thing I can highlight. Often it sits somewhere in R&D or corporate strategy; the risk is it can be sometimes a little bit not close enough to the business units.
Köster GmbH	In a family company, when the owner drives it, you can think long term in a way that is rarely possible in a large corporate.
Helm AG	We want to be as open as possible to efficiency gains but also business model growth. It's part of corporate development.
Metron AG*	We are not a business unit ourselves but more like a technology competence center that supports different business units. Because we are part of the technical division, our perspective is naturally very technology-focused.
Teknor SE*	It's more on the R&D side, directly under the CTO. The idea is also how to get the next big things for us because we're lacking a bit of organic growth.
Lumera*	It's not really a specific venture clienting unit anymore — it's more decentralised now. We experienced that it's not necessary to have it centralised. Make-or-buy decisions exist in every part of the company, and being decentralised means being more embedded in business departments.
Scania AB	It's positioned in the R&D department — TRATON R&D has an innovation management team. They are two people working with startup business development and now do this with venture clienting.
Alpha Corp AB*	We have a little bit of a divided R&D. We have the traditional R&D and then a separate part responsible for being more flexible, finding new ways of working, and making quicker decisions — and that is where startup collaboration sits.
Sovian AG*	We were located under innovation within a global function. We have now moved out of innovation and into strategy — so now we're only venture capital and venture clienting. Our reporting lines are now quite short, much closer to top-level management than before.

Appendix F: Additional Quotes The Role of Management Support and Culture

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Service Provider 4	You should have a strong mandate from top management — it's still a long-term game. You have a portfolio strategy; not every pilot will become a winner. You have to have the possibility to do several projects and pick the right ones to go further.
Service Provider 2	Culture can be an accelerator — if they're open, it's much easier to get started. But if they're not open, it's usually not that the whole organization is resistant. You just need to find early pioneers to do groundwork with to create success cases.
Service Provider 3	You cannot push venture clienting on a company that does not really care about innovation or does not want to change anything. If your whole company is happy with how things were for the past 50 years, it would be very challenging.
Service Provider 5	If it wouldn't work if it required a culture shift because that takes quite a long time. Venture clienting is a service and there will always be people who want to use the service and people who don't — we start with the excited ones, generate wins, and then convince the sceptical ones over time.
Service Provider 6	To really get some first success, you just need a business owner who's convinced about it and some relatively senior people in the company. Then you can further build your structures.
Karls Oy*	The challenge is getting startups, our innovation team, and the business unit in sync with each other. It often happens that we have some innovations maturing but they don't meet the needs going on. And when there are needs, there is no time for it.
LH Innovation Hub	Culture of innovation, attitude toward startups — it's those soft factors that play a role. Sometimes you have new management coming in and saying 'not invented here' and putting things on hold — even if all processes and guardrails are aligned perfectly.
Helm AG	You need certain people who are just entrepreneurs who always try out something first to be your fanboys. That will then make sure more people come towards you. And you need a culture where learning is considered a success already.
Metron AG	If top management actively supports innovation and communicates that it is important, it creates a completely different dynamic within the organization. At the same time, it is very much a people-driven process — often it depends less on formal structures and more on individual motivation.
Lumera*	Most important are stakeholder commitment — the hardest to get — a culture open for failures, and the company being ready to take innovation in, with IT capacity, legal, procurement. Also incentivization — employees need intrinsic motivation to spend time on innovation projects.
Scania AB	At Scania we have a very strong lean culture and continuous improvement culture. So internally the hurdles are very much lower for process projects. For product innovations, regulations and testing make it more problematic and it requires a mindset shift.
Everta AB*	Culture plays a big part in terms of how external innovation is tackled. In general we are a very progressive company. But obviously being in a corporate, things are moving slower — and if there is no welcoming attitude, it is very hard to implement anything.
Sovian AG*	In a company like Sovian, people have usually been working there for a very long time and doing things in one way for a long time. The receptiveness to change is not so high. We also position ourselves carefully so as not to come across as innovation theatre — we always try to show numbers.

Appendix G: Additional Quotes Internal Communication and Stakeholder Management

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Service Provider 4	You need some internal people that are highly motivated and support the organization, working together with startups. You also need backing in communication and marketing to make this visible to the outside and the inside.
Service Provider 3	The core of our role boils down to stakeholder management. Someone needs to do the translation — corporates have a completely different language than startups. Startups want quick commitment. Corporates have other priorities and cannot dedicate 100% to one project.
Service Provider 5	No one wants to be told that what they're doing is a bad job. Everyone should feel like part of the solution, not the problem. 'I found this great solution to my own problem' — that should be the mentality, not 'someone has found a solution and I'm obsolete.'
Service Provider 1	Communication is key — create awareness, repeat the message about why startups, over and over again, even though it feels like you've said it so many times. This is really critical, especially in the first one to two years.
Service Provider 6	I think if you make it clear why you're doing it, what's the benefit, and that you create a win–win situation on both sides, then I don't see that there's a lot of friction risk. If the business units perceive it as pushing, you have a structural problem.
Köster GmbH	Venture clienting, innovation — these are all nothing worth if you don't start with the internal network. You have to pick people who are motivated, but also not neglect the others: show them the long-term impact and build relationships and a routine.
Karls Oy*	We try to systematically take this awareness to different business teams — and of course there is still a lot of work to be done. The better we understand and speak each other's language in business and technology development, the faster we can move forward.
LH Innovation Hub	We go to lunch and learns of Lufthansa group or internal events and do myth-busting — a lot of people still have stereotypes attached to startups. We also rely on our transformation colleagues who do workshops and learning journeys where venture clienting is mentioned.
Metron AG*	We have defined contact persons within the different departments, particularly in R&D, with whom we are in regular exchange. We constantly introduce ourselves proactively, engage in conversations, and participate in internal events such as internal fairs.
Lumera*	We did in the first year nearly just marketing and communication. We really enabled and shared knowledge about startups — that they're not only three people in a garage, but can be a company with 40–50 employees and a real tangible solution.
Scania AB	Every time we want the owner of the problem to be in the project. This achieves commitment — I have committed, this is a great project, and then they will fight for it. Management should also say: you are allowed to do this, so that people know.
Alpha Corp AB*	The most important thing for a startup entering our ecosystem is to understand how their technology brings customer value or solves the problem — the technology itself we're not that interested in; it's the problem it solves.
Sovian AG*	The most important success factor is knowing your stakeholders very well. Stakeholders that stop the project at many points is a huge challenge — so understanding who they are and managing them is key to not having projects stopped unexpectedly.

Appendix H: Additional Quotes Exploration-Exploitation Balance and Venture Clienting

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Service Provider 2	We're clearly exploring technology from the outside. But we're also always building on the capabilities that someone internally has. Both are impacted — and the venture client process itself could be some kind of exploitation measurement because you are building internal capabilities.
Service Provider 3	Venture clienting is exploiting internal capabilities where it identifies problem owners and people willing to test outside solutions. And it is exploring by accessing cutting-edge startup technologies. It resonates so highly with the ambidexterity definition.
Service Provider 5	With venture clienting, you can kind of do a bit of both — exploration and exploitation. It is in itself almost an ambidextrous innovation tool in a way.
Köster GmbH	Venture clienting is generally about exploitation — optimising existing processes. But from that you can develop disruptive things that change the industry, for example when the impulse from a pilot leads you to say: we can become a fully digital general contractor.
LH Innovation Hub	It tends a little bit more into exploration. The business units have to meet their KPIs and don't have capacity for exploration — so we do it for them. But it always needs a quantitative impact hypothesis, because we don't just explore for its own sake.
Helm AG	Venture clienting is the perfect equilibrium of ambidexterity — it actually does both. You explore and exploit at the same time, and that's why my boss loves it so much.
Teknor SE*	In our case it's more about bringing new capabilities into Teknor* — it's about capability building. Maybe we have some capabilities but we can't reach the next level without external help. So it's more exploration of capabilities we don't have, roughly 60–70% exploration for us.
Lumera*	We are exploiting existing potentials as a bank — we don't need to really explore new things because we are not ready to do that yet. If I were not working in a bank I would say venture clienting should be used more for exploration, but in our context it's around 95% exploitation.
Scania AB	It's absolutely about exploring — we want to see, try out new technology. If we master the technology ourselves already, we don't need to do anything like that. But process projects have lower internal hurdles because of our strong lean culture.
Alpha Corp AB*	We work with startups to find new business opportunities where their technology enables us to build a new product or value proposition. We see a startup as a way to get there faster — it's fundamentally about exploration that eventually becomes exploitation through integration.
Sovian AG*	We do more exploit than explore, because we have an innovation function that should do more of the exploration. We are about exploiting already existing knowledge in a different way. Process topics are the low-hanging fruit — that's always our focus.

Appendix I: Additional Quotes The Pull Towards Exploitation

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Service Provider 4	In the heart, venture clienting is always a make-or-buy decision. It must be something that is existing — there is a product you can buy. Most topics where VCL is really strong are about efficiency and process improvements.
Service Provider 3	The strategic goal is creating impact — having a monetary value attached to projects. It is either boosting revenue streams, creating new business, tapping into new markets, or cutting costs. You cannot just create a fancy title and call something innovation where it does not generate any monetary value.
Service Provider 5	Product innovation is much more difficult, takes more time, but also the reward is bigger. Process is where it's easier to start — that's also how it is in the end in the distribution of cases.
Köster GmbH	In a service-based business like construction, it is almost 100% process-oriented. We are a general contractor — we manage very well. Our core business is efficient management, so everything we look for digitises or optimises those existing management processes.
Karls Oy*	The big change we made is that previously we focused on R&D projects like a new sensor or lower-emission technology. Now there has been this huge AI revolution and through that there are a lot of new solutions in the category of process innovations — for example AI for customer service.
LH Innovation Hub	There are so many use cases where you can increase efficiency of booking processes, HR processes, admin. These are the ones that are saving us in terms of impact and give us leeway to also do product innovation.
Helm AG	We're a distribution company — we don't have R&D. So venture clienting is currently around 70–80% process-related: digitising, automating, and optimising processes from sales through to sustainability and legal.
Metron AG*	We have started to look more at process topics because we learned from others that it makes a lot of sense. Especially since process topics often come with cost savings, and there are many solutions on the market that are worth exploring — even though our natural orientation is product.
Lumera*	Therefore it's fine to do it like that — exploitation of existing capabilities and processes. Banking is very straightforward in its product, so process efficiency and making our internal operations better is where venture clienting fits most naturally for us.
Scania AB	At Scania we have a very strong lean culture and continuous improvement culture. So internally the hurdles are very much lower for process projects. For product innovations, regulations and testing make it more problematic.
Sovian AG*	Always process. That's the low-hanging fruit, always. Product is difficult — that's what we sell, and in the industry we're in, product development cycles are very long. In contrast, process solutions can be validated quickly.

Appendix J: Additional Quotes Interaction with Internal R&D

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Service Provider 4	Venture clienting would start in R&D in a lot of companies, but you can do a lot of things that support R&D without competing with it — a better simulation tool, a design tool, a testing tool. If you're limited to R&D you will skip most of the potential.
Service Provider 2	I am aware of quite some venture client units working quite heavily with R&D. In R&D you try out really cool new things for the next years, and in those fields you have an intersection with really innovative technology — so R&D is just a venture client like any other department for us.
Service Provider 3	If R&D gets stuck, it can also be a venture clienting candidate. I've seen projects where R&D topics were mixed with daily topics and venture clienting was used as part of R&D where there is a startup market. The only thing that disqualifies VCL is an absence of quality startup supply.
Service Provider 6	BMW's Startup Garage is a good example of a product-focused VCL unit sitting very close to R&D. It depends on where you are as a corporate and whether your horizon is horizon one or horizon two–three.
Karls Oy*	We are part of this broader machine technology and innovation organization, which combines traditional R&D, IT, and innovation. The innovation team supports business teams that have a need — not to develop products we already have, but for new customer needs where no task or resources exist in product development.
Metron AG*	We have regular meetings with R&D departments. Each R&D unit has its own innovation managers. We are in continuous exchange with them — providing input, discussing new developments, asking about their challenges, and adapting to their processes rather than forcing them into ours.
Teknor SE*	We are not replacing R&D but adding to it.
Scania AB	We have a Scania Innovation Table — we meet cross-functionally once a month and discuss different topics. When we have a problem we put it up there and see: has anybody else solved this? Can we solve it? Do you have some technology that could help? We try to avoid double work.
Alpha Corp AB*	We have our own R&D people, but sometimes you need to learn something new. A good example is xxx — we started by working with a startup, then bought their IP, then eventually acquired the whole company. That trajectory from startup partnership into R&D ownership is the model.
Sovian AG*	We have an innovation function that should do more of the exploration. We are about exploiting already existing knowledge in a different way — finding proven solutions that R&D hasn't needed to develop itself. For adoption, internal knowledge and relationships become essential, which is why we step back from external support at that stage.

Appendix K: Additional Quotes Exploratory Applications and the Maturity Effect

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Service Provider 4	At BMW, venture clienting started in R&D, then expanded to manufacturing, after sales, financial services, HR, strategy — all parts of the company. The more mature the unit becomes, the more broadly it serves, moving from exploration at the edges toward enterprise-wide exploitation.
Service Provider 2	The focus is moving to adoption — taking a much stronger role in that stage. Until now it was just: prove that venture clienting works. Now it's moving away from how many POCs you facilitated toward actually showing real impact.
Service Provider 3	We classify units into levels: level one is buying from startups without a dedicated process; level two has a partial process; level three — the BMW Startup Garages of this world — has a dedicated brand, over 50 pilots a year, and an ambassador network. That is the maturity trajectory.
Service Provider 5	We've seen it a lot where you use a startup technology from aviation in automotive — you are one of the first ones to use it in that market. You're exploring at company level even if not new to the world. Early-stage units do a lot of this firm-level exploration.
Köster GmbH	After almost half a year we already have four pain points in scouting and are starting our first two pilots — generative design for architecture planning. Very early stage, very explorative, but with a clear plan that if it works, it feeds into our operating model.
Karls Oy*	In practice, the big added value of the startup ecosystem is commercially mature solutions that we can validate quickly rather than co-develop. We shifted from R&D partnership projects — where time to value is very long — toward process innovations where the startup has a product ready to test.
LH Innovation Hub	We had a use case with xxx a year ago — at that point it was still exploratory for us. But it's not innovation anymore because it's just so established now and our competitors are doing it too. So what is exploration today may be pure exploitation in 12 months.
Helm AG	We're around 70–80% process/exploitation right now. Looking forward it's a bit more business model growth related — so the ratio will shift as we mature. We expect that as the unit becomes more established, we can also take on more exploratory topics.
Teknor SE*	We are collecting around 15–20 problems and aim for five POCs this year — that is the explorative phase. Once a pilot is successful, the real question becomes whether we scale it across the whole sales team or product line. That is where the shift from exploration to exploitation happens.
Lumera*	Success for us is not how many pilots but how many tools get into integration into the operating model. Management says what matters most is that employees work with AI in their daily business and learn. Exploration is the means; operating model integration is the end.

Appendix L: Additional Quotes Venture Clienting as a Distinct but Complementary Tool

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Service Provider 4	Venture clienting is complementary to CVC — at BMW there was BMW i Ventures doing CVC and the Startup Garage doing VCL. We could tell a startup: you need money or you need a client, we can give you both. They're not related — you can take just one or both. That's quite a good value proposition.
Service Provider 2	I'm proud of never having a venture client unit actually closing — and there seems to be a shift in CVC where they realised that to work well they actually can't be close enough to the business. VCL stays close to the business; CVC moves further out.
Service Provider 5	The average corporate venture capital fund survives only three and a half years. A lot have cancelled CVC because the results haven't been there. Venture clienting, by contrast — there are very few that have really stopped it. A lot are actually increasing it over time.
Service Provider 1	It's definitely not a substitution. If you want to make money with startups, CVC is the way. The question is whether you need those millions or whether it makes more sense to put them into good R&D and good pilots. I see both as complementary at different stages.
Service Provider 6	I think it's mainly complementary. I never heard: 'oh, we have CVC already, so we don't do venture clienting.' For me it's really complementary — they can feed each other as well. CVC and VCL serve different goals and different horizons.
Köster GmbH	We are doing all three vehicles — CVC through a fund we're invested in, venture clienting, and building new business models. The interaction is that a successful VCL pilot can inform a CVC investment decision: the pilot is essentially a due diligence for us. They are distinct but deliberately connected.
Karls Oy*	At the moment we don't really have any CVC activity at all. But the venture client model offers us a pretty unique perspective on which startup solutions actually generate value. It could offer a unique deal flow we could utilise in future direct investments — so VCL creates optionality for CVC.
LH Innovation Hub	Our endeavours in CVC shrink a little bit — it's not the main focus anymore. Venture clienting on the contrary is really growing. I would not invest in a startup without having done venture clienting with them first — it's just a better due diligence.
Helm AG	Venture clienting is very close to the core — horizon one, mostly evolutionary. Whereas venture capital investments can go completely revolutionary to disruptive — horizon three. They serve different strategic purposes and should not be confused.
Scania AB	We have a corporate venture capital arm. They help us assess companies from a technical point of view and sometimes we see that we can cooperate with a company and then try to put together a pilot. So it's a triangle — CVC, VCL, and business — that feed each other.
Alpha Corp SE*	We had a case where we started with a partnership, then bought IP, then eventually acquired the whole company. The whole trajectory — from exploratory VCL to full acquisition — shows that these tools work in sequence rather than as alternatives.
Everta AB*	Is there a startup in the market already doing 80% of what we're looking for? Then there's no point reinventing the wheel — we can say let's partner, invest, or acquire. Or if no one's good enough, we'll just build it ourselves. VCL is one node in a broader decision tree.
Sovian AG*	I wish there was more of a bridge between venture clienting and venture capital investment. Some companies talk about using VCL as a runway into investment. Our investment thesis is very different from our VCL one for now — VCL is really solving problems that are there, while VC may have a different thesis.

Appendix M: Additional Quotes "Test Before Invest" as a Linking Mechanism

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Service Provider 4	Venture clienting can reduce risk for CVC — if a startup is already working as a supplier for the company before investment, you have an internal proof, you know exactly how good the product is. You have a market perspective. So it's like an insider trade in the best sense.
Service Provider 2	After you've piloted, after you feel the collaboration is going well, then you could use some kind of CVC investment approach to get the partnership to the next level — for example, get exclusive rights if they want to sell the company. VCL pilot first, then CVC escalation.
Service Provider 5	Test before you invest — that's one thing we start to hear and I also start to use it. Most CVCs are strategic investors. And to assess strategic potential, you need to really look: does this work in our business? A lot of companies now have CVCs under pressure to do venture clienting and bring value to business units.
Service Provider 1	I see a lot of benefit in invest after testing. It helps you do better due diligence which gives you an edge over other VCs you compete with. And M&A is not leveraged enough right now — US corporations are good at it, the question is why Europe is lagging behind.
Service Provider 6	After a venture clienting pilot you know the solution works in your context. That makes a subsequent investment or partnership much less risky — you're not betting on a pitch deck, you're betting on demonstrated performance.
Köster GmbH	We interact with our fund partners who do the full financial due diligence. When I look at a startup in a VCL project, I can ask the fund: how do you assess this company? They know the founders' backgrounds, the investment history. Together, our pilot provides technical proof and they provide financial proof — a combined due diligence.
Karls Oy*	The venture client model also offers us a pretty unique perspective on which startup solutions actually generate value, because we are an early stage customer for those startups. It could offer a kind of unique deal flow that we could utilise in direct investments if the startup solution is in our strategic interest to own.
LH Innovation Hub	I would not invest in a startup without having done venture clienting with them first, right? Because you're not just betting on a pitch — you know the product flies in your company, you know the startup in and out. No due diligence is as good as a venture clienting use case.
Helm AG	We started with venture clienting in 2024 and are now within this year and next year also looking into venture capital for investments. So we will become a corporate venturing unit. VCL is the proven foundation on which we'll layer CVC — test before invest.
Metron AG*	Sometimes after a successful pilot project the idea emerged that the startup could be interesting for a minority investment — in such cases we explore whether there are additional topics where further scouting would make sense. It was opportunistic rather than systematic, but the pilot was always the gateway.
Teknor SE*	If we do the venture clienting process right we can also find M&A candidates for the future — we go through the process, see it works, do a due diligence, and then say it's really valid to invest in and can then merge the VCL process with the M&A process.
Everta AB*	A couple of years ago we looked into a startup we were considering investing in, but before we even came to that recommendation we did a pilot in market — a collaboration just to see what the synergies were. We would not go in and say: yeah, let's just invest; looks great guys. The pilot comes first.

Appendix N: Additional Quotes Scaling Enablers

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Service Provider 3	In companies with widely adopted innovation culture, it's so much easier to test something and then scale it across departments. That's exactly where you see the full benefit of VCL — the culture is the scaling infrastructure.
Service Provider 5	One of the hardest things is to scale something. Teams change, priorities change, the pilot took very long and the momentum is gone. The scope is much bigger, the investment much bigger, there are more people involved — the whole situation gets more complex. You need someone who helps overcome these roadblocks and doesn't give up.
Service Provider 1	Step one: get quick wins with 4–5 problems. Step two: generate a proof point and build awareness so problem inflow becomes more natural. Step three: integrate IT and procurement, scale volume. At some point decide internal vs. hybrid — that's the classic journey.
Service Provider 6	The beauty of the venture clienting model is that to really get some first success you don't need too much — a business owner who's convinced and some relatively senior people. From there you can further build structures. Low entry barriers enable fast early wins that then enable scaling.
Köster GmbH	Success is not just impact in euros but also reach — how many different areas and functions did you touch? What's the qualitative narrative: we found six solutions in two months for a problem that colleagues had been looking for for five years. That qualitative proof is what unlocks the next budget cycle.
Karls Oy*	We accept that at every stage we can be told it's not worth moving forward — it's a portfolio game. Not every case we start will end with a new startup supplier. That acceptance of failure as a portfolio outcome, not a project failure, is what enables scaling without fear.
LH Innovation Hub	Identify your champions or angels or influencers in your corporate and utilise them — go with their flow as long as you're compliant and then generate impact. Also check what strategic initiatives are lining up and see if there's a potential venture clienting case attached — that's how you create natural pull.
Helm AG	Within the process I guarantee everyone they don't need more than 10 hours invested — excluding the pilot. My job is to cover the back of my colleagues so they have time to step in only when really necessary. Making the process frictionless for the problem owner is the key scaling enabler.
Metron AG*	A key learning from a successful process project was that even if you apply the same effort in other projects, outcomes vary significantly depending on the people involved. It all depends on the individual motivation of the business unit — that's what makes or breaks the adoption.
Alpha Corp AB*	Once you get confirmation from customers that the technology solves a real problem, the next step is scaling globally — and our customer base is global. The startup needs to be able to support that globally, and that is where many startups underestimate the jump from prototype to production scale.
Sovian AG*	For solutions that are successful, we go into adoption preparation — checking cyber, IT, procurement, legal criteria. Then a longer agreement and the scaling process begins. We select problems with scaling ability across the company so it's not a vacuum problem but a solution that can roll out across factories or business areas.

Appendix O: Additional Quotes Implementation Tensions

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Service Provider 2	The business units like working with us, but they're usually not experienced in onboarding new suppliers, and with every project there's a different stakeholder. Most of them don't have the capabilities to guide through internal processes. That's why the venture client unit is the intersection point where things always come together.
Service Provider 5	Teams change, priorities change, the pilot took very long and the momentum is gone — one of the most common implementation failures. The scope is much bigger, the investment much bigger, there are more people involved. The whole situation gets more complex and you need someone dedicated to navigating it.
Service Provider 1	The biggest challenge is maintaining a consistent and continuous problem inflow. It feels like being a salesperson selling something while you just want to create a win–win. People get meeting fatigue, stop too early, and for some people with weak internal networks this phase is just not the right job.
Service Provider 6	IT, procurement, legal — those functional units all have more experience than the venture clienting manager in their domain. You need a very partnership-oriented approach, not an adversarial one. Make them understand: this is what we do, here is our process, what do we need from you to run pilots?
Köster GmbH	IT, procurement, data protection — that's always named at every roundtable. Before we start any project now, we play through all scenarios with IT in advance. The most important thing: never give them the feeling you're a service to be used. You're a partner.
Karls Oy*	There is a kind of resistance — business units feeling that things are happening outside their control. At the point when the innovation team becomes a business unit that goes out to find customers and sell to them, it starts to get a little out of sync and disorganized. You have to avoid that dynamic.
Metron AG*	In Germany, the works council plays a significant role especially when it comes to personal data or automation. Even if automation does not actually lead to job losses, it is often perceived that way in business case calculations, which can create resistance at the adoption stage.
Teknor SE*	We also have some colleagues who really love to do exploration at fairs, come in contact with startups, and create cases around the startups — starting with the startup rather than the problem. That's also a resistance — people preferring ad-hoc contacts over the structured process.
Lumera*	There are so many departments that need to be involved to get a project into operations. You need management backing in every department to get capacities, budget, the processes aligned — and if they don't like it, sometimes they won't do it, and then you start from zero again.
Scania AB	The engineering team — if they have something they cannot solve, they want to solve it themselves.

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Sovian AG*	People get scared about startups: how do we know this company will survive? What do we do if it goes bankrupt? These attitudes come from fear almost. And then there is also the problem of someone initiating the project but then moving roles — and then the control and priority of the project goes away.

Appendix P: Additional Quotes Role of Service Providers

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Service Provider 2	That's why there will always be some demand for external VCL support — it gives flexibility that internal hiring cannot. You can scale up and down depending on what the company needs.
Service Provider 3	The core of our role boils down to stakeholder management. Someone needs to do the translation — corporates have a completely different language than startups. Startups want quick commitment. Corporates have other priorities and cannot dedicate 100% to one project.
Service Provider 5	Our firm is really unique because you have corporates cooperating together on different topics, peer-to-peer learning, and supporting each other. They are more long-term involved. That's quite a different model than project-based service providers.
Service Provider 1	It is possible to build VCL internally as well. The question is: is it faster and cheaper to do it with external support? Both ways work. In year three to four that's a question you need to ask yourself. A hybrid mode works quite well for most.
Service Provider 6	They are great and they are good to help you get firepower in the beginning. One thing I would challenge though is domain expertise — people in the end have a certain trust if you are somewhat familiar with what they do and come from their company or their realm.
Köster GmbH	After years of building internal capability at Deutsche Bahn/Schenker, we have the knowledge to set it up ourselves. What we still need externally are partners with very deep sector focus — not generalists who scout anything, but people who know the construction ecosystem in detail.
Karls Oy*	In practice, the big added value they provide is that they have a network in the startup ecosystem that we don't have.
LH Innovation Hub	We decided not to use an external service provider because we needed to build the stakeholder relationships and domain knowledge ourselves. In aviation, trust and domain specificity matter enormously — an outsider would struggle to build that from day one.
Helm AG	I could search with Copilot, but I can't verify funding, founder quality, or whether the startup actually solves our specific case. They also give neutral feedback on both the startup and our own problem owners.
Metron AG*	We regularly reassess our needs. Sometimes we need full process support, sometimes just tools. We also use external partners to challenge and improve our processes even if we already have an established setup — the outside perspective retains value even for mature units.
Teknor SE*	We don't have the capability for startup scouting internally — it's too broad.

Case / Service Provider	Quote
Lumera*	We worked with a consulting firm for one year to set up the process, governance, and knowledge. Then we said: now we're ready and can do it on our own.
Scania AB	XXX's role is really the matchmaking — from startups to corporates. They provide databases and sometimes financing channels. For us they are more a project-by-project partner depending on our capacity to take on cases.
Sovian AG*	Up until adoption phase we used consultants — for setting up the programme, running pilots, scheduling. For the adoption phase we need to talk to the right people internally and share business knowledge that can't easily be shared externally. So the service provider relationship naturally narrows as you mature.